

Arabic, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Arabic one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Arabic letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, right-to-left, so you learn to read سلام *and* learn that it means “peace” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already reads Arabic simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Arabic changes the etymology game entirely. The Romance and Germanic volumes trace words back to Latin or Germanic roots; Arabic doesn’t need tracing — its roots are on the *surface*. Nearly every Arabic word is built from a **three-consonant root** carrying a core meaning, poured into fixed patterns, so *peace*, *Islam*, *Muslim*, and the greeting *salaam* are visibly one family (s-l-m), the way this whole series wishes Latin were. That root system is taught as the organizing engine. A recurring thread is Arabic’s long shadow over **Spanish**, another language in this project: the article *al-* smuggled into English *algebra* and *alcohol*, and the sun-letter assimilation still audible in Spanish *azúcar* (from *as-sukkar*) — every such form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of Spanish is assumed.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Arabic out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

The Arabic greetings — and, taught through them, how to read the Arabic script and how the three-consonant **root** builds nearly every word. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs, so you learn to read the word and understand it at once. *Practice lessons: lessons/AR-C01-*.md.*

Three facts about the script, and one about the roots

1. **Right to left.** The first letter of a word is on the *right*.
2. **Letters connect** (cursive-style), so a letter’s shape shifts a little by position; a few are “one-way” — they join the letter before but not the one after.
3. **Short vowels are usually invisible.** Long vowels ($\bar{a}$ $\bar{i}$ $\bar{u}$) are full letters; the short $a/i/u$ between consonants are simply known, not written.

And the engine of the whole language: most Arabic words are a **root** of three consonants carrying a core meaning, poured into fixed vowel **patterns**. The classic is **k–t–b** (writing): *kataba* (he wrote), *kitāb* (book), *kātib* (writer), *maktab* (office = “a place of writing”), *maktaba* (library) — six words, one root. Every greeting below is a root plus a pattern; watch the roots surface.

1.1 سلام (*salām*) — “peace,” the most famous root

The letters in this word

Four letters, read **right to left**: س (*sīn*, “s”), ل (*lām*, “l”), ا (*alif*, long “ā”), م (*mīm*, “m”). Warm up on the tiny word لا (*lā*, “no”) — *lām* then *alif*, fusing into one shape — then read سلام right to left: *s · l · ā · m* → *salām*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

سلام (*salām*), “peace.” Root **s-l-m** (*wholeness, safety, peace*) — an enormous family: *salām* (peace), *islām* (submission → peace with God), *muslim* (“one who submits,” the *mu-i-* pattern), *sallama* (to greet). It reaches past Arabic: Hebrew **shalom** is the *same* Semitic root. English meets it as the borrowing *salaam* and the name *Salīm*.

Why it’s said this way

On its own, *salām* is a warm “peace” — and the seed of the full greeting *as-salāmu ‘alaykum*, coming shortly. To say it is to wish the other person peace, not merely to signal “hello.”

1.2 مرحبا (*marḥaban*) — “hello,” i.e. “there’s room for you”

The letters in this word

Three new letters: ب (*bāʾ*, “b,” one dot *below*), ر (*rāʾ*, a tapped “r,” one-way), ح (*ḥāʾ*, a heavy, throaty “h”). With م and ا from *salām*, read باب (*bāb*, “door”), حب (*ḥubb*, “love”), then مرحبا right to left → *marḥaban*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

مرحبا (*marḥaban*), the casual “hi.” Root **r-h-b** (*spaciousness*): *raḥuba* (to be wide), *raḥb* (roomy) → *marḥaban* = “[a place of] welcome, there is room for you.” Not an empty sound but a little sentence — as *buenos días* was once a blessing. Reply: *marḥabtayn*, “two welcomes.”

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

Dots on a shared skeleton distinguish many letters: ب / ت / ث (b / t / th) are one shape with one dot below / two above / three above. Learn one skeleton and you often get three letters.

1.3 ال (*al-*) — “the,” hiding in English *algebra*

The letters in this word

No new letters — just ا (alif) and ل (lām), the two you already read in *salām*, written together and attached to the front of a noun.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

ال (*al-*, “the”). For ~800 years Arabic was the Mediterranean’s language of science and trade, and English and Spanish absorbed its words *with al- attached*: **algebra** (*al-jabr*), **alcohol** (*al-kuḥl*), **algorithm** (*al-Khwārizmī*), **alchemy**, **almanac**. Learning Arabic *al-* is meeting an old friend.

Grammar Lens

Sun letters. Before certain consonants (س *s*, ش *sh*, ن *n*, ر *r*, ت *t*...) the *l* of *al-* assimilates and the letter doubles: *al- + salām* → *as-salām*; *al- + nūr* → *an-nūr*. Before “moon letters” (خ *kh*, ك *k*...) the *l* stays: *al-khayr*. You can hear the rule inside Spanish *azúcar* (from *as-sukkar*).

1.4 السلام عليكم (*as-salāmu ‘alaykum*) — “peace be upon you”

The letters in this word

Three new letters, all in *‘alaykum*: ع (*‘ayn*, a throat-tightening with no English equal — approximate it), ي (*yā’*, “y”), ك (*kāf*, “k”). The rest you can already read: السلام is *al- + salām*.

السلام عليكم = *as-salāmu* (*al- + salām*, sun-letter *s* assimilated) + *‘alaykum* (“upon you [all]”). Literally “the peace [be] upon you” — and note there is

no word for “is”: Arabic sets the two phrases side by side and lets “is” be understood (where Spanish needs *está*).

Why it’s said this way

The universal greeting; its reply is fixed: **وعليكم السلام** (*wa-‘alaykum as-salām*) — “and upon you the peace.” You give peace; it is returned. Any time, any register, real weight — you are wishing *peace*, not saying “hi.”

1.5 صباح الخير (*ṣabāḥ al-khayr*) — “morning of goodness”

The letters in this word

Two new letters: **ص** (*ṣād*, an *emphatic*/heavy “s” — a different letter from **س**) and **خ** (*khāʾ*, a throat-scrape, the same sound as **Spanish j**). With the rest known, read **صباح** (*ṣabāḥ*, “morning”) and **خير** (*khayr*, “goodness”).

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

صباح (*ṣabāḥ*), root **ṣ-b-h** (dawn/waking: *ṣubḥ* dawn, *aṣbaḥa* “to become, reach morning”). **خير** (*khayr*, “good, goodness”), root **kh-y-r**. Together **صباح الخير** = “morning of the goodness” — *al-khayr* keeps its *l* (moon letter **ل**), a clean contrast with *as-salām*.

Why it’s said this way

Reply: **صباح النور** (*ṣabāḥ an-nūr*) — “morning of the *light*” (*al-* + *nūr*, sun-letter *n* assimilated). You wish goodness; they wish you light.

1.6 مساء الخير (*masāʾ al-khayr*) — “evening of goodness”

The letters in this word

One new mark: ء (*hamza*), a glottal stop — the catch in the middle of “uh-oh.” At the end of مساء it gives *masāʾ*. Everything else here you can already read.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

مساء (*masāʾ*, “evening”), root **m-s-w**: *amsā* “to become, reach evening” — the exact mirror of *aṣḥaḥa*. Arabic names morning and evening as matched events (each with its own “to become” verb), where French *soir* and Spanish *tarde* both merely meant “late.” مساء الخير = “evening of goodness”; reply مساء النور (*masāʾ an-nūr*).

1.7 شكرا (*shukran*) — “thank you”

The letters in this word

Two new letters: ش (*shīn*, “sh” — it is س *plus three dots*) and ك (*kāf*, “k,” met in *‘alaykum*). Read شكرا right to left → *shukran*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

شكرا (*shukran*), root **sh-k-r** (*gratitude*): *shukr* (thanks), *shākir* (thankful), *mashkūr* (thanked). Look: *shākir* and *mashkūr* sit in the *exact* patterns as *kātib* (writer) and *maktūb* (written) from the root engine — learn a pattern once, it works on every root. (This same root, through Persian, gave Hindi/Urdu *shukriyā*.) Reply: عفو! (*afwan*), “it’s nothing.”

1.8 The day of greetings

When	Greeting	Reply
casual	<i>marḥaban</i>	<i>marḥabtayn</i>
any time	<i>as-salāmu ‘alaykum</i>	<i>wa-‘alaykum as-salām</i>
morning	<i>ṣabāḥ al-khayr</i>	<i>ṣabāḥ an-nūr</i>
evening	<i>masā’ al-khayr</i>	<i>masā’ an-nūr</i>
thanks	<i>shukran</i>	<i>‘afwan</i>

Read these back right to left before checking: السلام عليكم, مرحبا, سلام. شكرا, مساء الخير, صباح الخير. About a dozen letters, each learned inside a real greeting. Two engines did the work: the three-consonant **root** (s-l-m, sh-k-r) and the attached **al-** with its sun/moon assimilation. Next chapter: introducing yourself (*ismī...*, “my name is”) and how Arabic marks “you” by gender (*anta* / *anti*).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

اسمي أرُون. (*ismī Arun* — “My name is Arun.”)
ما اسمك؟ (*mā ismuka* — “What is your name?”)

Built from Chapter 1’s letters and roots, each piece taken apart, then assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/AR-C02-*.md.*

2.1 اسم (*ism*) — “name”

The letters in this word

No new letters — ا (*alif*), س (*sīn*), م (*mīm*) are all from Chapter 1. Read اسم right to left → *ism*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

اسم (*ism*, “name”), root **s–m–w**. It is a **Semitic** word, the cousin of Hebrew *shem* (“name”) — the same pairing you saw with *salām* / *shalom*. It has *no* tie to the Indo-European *name* / Latin *nōmen*: Arabic belongs to a different family entirely, and its word for “name” is its own.

2.2 ي (-ī) — “my,” a letter stuck on the end

The letters in this word

ي (*yāʾ*), met in *‘alaykum*, here does a new job: attached to the end of a noun it means “my.”

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

Arabic doesn’t use a separate word for “my” — it **glues a suffix** onto the noun: اسم (*ism*, “name”) + ي (-ī, “my”) = اسمي (*ismī*, “my name”). This is the same trick as the attached *al-* from Chapter 1: Arabic loves to build meaning by fastening little pieces onto a word, not by stringing separate words together.

2.3 ... اسمي (*ismī ...*) — “my name is...,” with no “is”

اسمي (my name) + name = *ismī ... Ismī Arun.* = “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens

No word for “is” — again. Recall from *as-salāmu ‘alaykum* (Ch. 1) that Arabic sets two words side by side and lets “is” be understood. So *ismī Arun* is literally “my-name Arun.” Arabic shares this **zero copula** with the Dravidian languages (Tamil *eṇ peyar Arun*) — a striking meeting of two unrelated families on the same habit.

2.4 أنت (*anta / anti*) — “you,” marked by *gender*

The letters in this word

Two new letters: أ (*alif* with a *hamza* seat, a glottal “a”-start) and ت (*tāʾ*, “t” — the ب/ت/ث skeleton from Ch. 1, two dots above). The final vowel is written only with a mark: أنت *anta*, أنتِ *anti*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

أنت is “you” — but Arabic splits it by the listener’s **gender**: *anta* to a man, *anti* to a woman. (Root of the pronoun aside, note the shared Semitic *-ta/-ti* ending, the same *t* that marks “you” in Hebrew *atta/att.*)

Grammar Lens

A different axis of “you.” The European and Dravidian tracks split “you” by *register* (familiar vs. respectful — *tū/vous, nī/nīṅaḷ*). Arabic splits it by *gender*: *anta* (to a man) vs. *anti* (to a woman). Same pronoun, a wholly different distinction — you choose by *who you’re talking to*, not how formal you are.

2.5 ما (mā) — “what”

The letters in this word

No new letters: م (*m*) + ا (*alif*, long ā) → ما *mā* — the little word you already read as a warm-up in Chapter 1.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

ما (*mā*, “what”) is the everyday question-word for things. (Arabic has a second, *mādhā*, for “what” before verbs; *mā* is the one you want before a noun, as in “what [is] your name?”)

2.6 ما اسمك؟ (mā ismuka / ismuki) — “what’s your name?”

ما اسمك = اسم (*ism*, name) + ك (*kāf*, the “your” suffix) — and *it too is gendered*: *ismuka* (a man’s name), *ismuki* (a woman’s). So ما اسمك؟ is literally “**what [is] your-name?**” — no “is,” the possessive glued on, the gender in the suffix.

Grammar Lens

Notice the matched pair: “my name” takes ي (*-ī*), “your name” takes ك (*-ka/-ki*). Answer with *ismī Arun*. The suffixes are the whole grammar

of the exchange.

2.7 تشرفنا (*tasharrafnā*) — “pleased to meet you”

The letters in this word

Uses ت (*tāʾ*, just met), ش (*shīn*) and ر (*rāʾ*) from Ch. 1, plus ف (*fāʾ*, “f”).

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

تشرفنا (*tasharrafnā*), root **sh-r-f** (*honour, nobility*): *sharaf* (honour), *sharīf* (noble — the English borrowing *sherif* of Mecca, and, distantly, the title behind *sheriff*). *tasharrafnā* means literally “**we have been honoured**” — to meet you is presented as an honour received. A more literal option is فرصة سعيدة (*furṣa saʿīda*, “a happy occasion”).

2.8 The whole exchange

Arabic	English
اسمي ميرا.	My name is Mira.
ما اسمك؟	What’s your name?
اسمي أرون.	My name is Arun.
تشرفنا.	Pleased to meet you.

Every piece from the root-and-suffix engine: *ism* (root s-m-w, Hebrew *shem*), the glued *-ī* (“my”) and *-ka/-ki* (“your”), *tasharrafnā* (root sh-r-f, “honour”). And two Arabic habits: it drops “is” entirely (the **zero copula**, shared with the Dravidian languages), and it marks “you” by **gender** (*anta/anti*), not register. Next chapter: *kayfa ḥāluka?* (“how are you?”) and *al-ḥamdu lillāh* — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

3.1 ح, خ, ج — the dots trick, on a brand-new body

Back in Lesson 4 you learned a whole family of letters that share one **bowl** and differ only by dots. Arabic does the *same trick* on a **second** skeleton — a curvy **hook-and-tail body** — giving three more common letters. Learn the body once; the dots do the rest, exactly as before.

Script — The hook-and-tail family

Every letter here is the **same shape**: a rounded **hook** at the top flowing into a **tail that drops below the line**. Only the dot changes:

letter	sound	the dot
ح <i>ḥāʾ</i>	ḥ — a deep, breathy “h” (from the throat)	no dot
خ <i>khāʾ</i>	kh — like the <i>ch</i> in Scottish “ loch ”	one dot above
ج <i>jīm</i>	j — as in “ j am”	one dot below

It is the bowl-family idea reborn: one skeleton, the dots deciding everything. Say the dial — **no dot / above / below** → **ḥ / kh / j**.

Script — Draw them

- ح (*ḥāʾ*) — the hook body, then the descending tail; **no dot**. From Phoenician **ḥēth** (“fence”) — the ancestor of Latin **H**.
- خ (*khāʾ*) — the **same** body, plus **one dot above**. (Arabic built *khāʾ* from *ḥāʾ* by adding the dot — no separate Latin cousin, but you

already know the shape.)

- ج (*jīm*) — the same body, plus **one dot below**. From Phoenician **gīml** (“camel”) — the great-grandparent of Greek *gamma* and Latin **C/G**.

Script — Where you’ve seen it — خير

You have already read خير (*khayr*, “good/well”) inside the Chapter 1 greeting الخير صباح (*ṣabāḥ al-khayr*, “good morning”). It **opens with** خ — the hook-body plus one dot above. You now know the first letter of a word you’ve been saying since Lesson... one.

Your turn

- *Write it:* the same hook-and-tail body three times, then dot them — ح (none), خ (above), ج (below)
- *Say it:* the dial — “no dot, above, below — ḥ, kh, j”
- *Say it:* “خ opens خير — the ‘good’ in *ṣabāḥ al-khayr*”

Before you move on

What do ح, خ, ج share, and what tells them apart? (One **hook-and-tail body**; the **dots** — none / above / below.) Which sound is خ, and where’s its dot? (**kh**, like *loch*; **one above**.) Which Chapter 1 word opens with خ? (خير, in *ṣabāḥ al-khayr*.) Next: ك (*kāf*) and ر (*rā*) — the last letters you need to write it.

3.2 ك and ر — an angular k, and an r that won’t hold hands

Two more shapes, and then — next lesson — you can write خير. Meet ك (*kāf*, “k”) and ر (*rā*, “r”). One is angular and new; the other revisits a rule you learned on the very first day.

Script — ك (*kāf*) — the angular k

Break it apart:

1. **the body** — an **angular upright**, bending like an open corner (not a curve — a hard angle). 2. **the inner stroke** — a small *hamza*-like flick tucked **inside** the angle.

ﻛ is *kāf*, a clean “k.” From Phoenician **kaph** (“palm of the hand”) — the ancestor of Greek *kappa* and Latin **K**. It joins its neighbours, changing shape by position like the other connectors.

Script — ﺝ (rā) — the little downward curve that breaks

Break it apart — there’s just *one piece*:

1. **the curve** — a short stroke that **curves down below the baseline** and stops. No dot, no loop.

ﺝ is *rā*, “r.” From Phoenician **rēsh** (“head”) — ancestor of Greek *rho* and Latin **R**. And here is the important rule: like **alif** (Lesson 1), **rā does not join to the letter after it** — it is one of the **six non-joiners**. So *rā* forces the pen to **lift**, just as *alif* did in *سلام*.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ﻛ — angular body + the inner flick
- *Write it:* ﺝ — one short downward curve below the line
- *Say it:* “*rā*, like *alif*, **breaks** — no joining the next letter”
- *Say it:* “*kaph* → K, *rēsh* → R — the Phoenician cousins again”

Before you move on

Describe ﻛ: angular or curved, and what sits inside? (**Angular** body with a small **inner stroke**.) What Latin letters descend from *kāf* and *rā*? (**K** and **R**.) What rule does ﺝ share with **alif**? (It is a **non-joiner** — the pen **lifts** after it.) Next: you assemble *خير* — and answer “how are you?”

3.3 خير and بخير — writing “good,” and how you say you’re well

Everything comes together. With خ (Lesson 7), ي (Lesson 5), and ﺝ (Lesson 8), you can now write *خير* (*khayr*, “good”) — the

word hiding in every “good morning” you’ve greeted with — and then بخير (*bi-khayr*, “well”), the everyday answer to “how are you?”

Script — Assemble خـ — right to left

Write it starting on the **right**, moving **left**:

1. خ (*khāʾ*) — the hook-body with **one dot above**, reaching left into...
2. ي (*yāʾ*) — joined in the middle (its two dots below), flowing into... 3. ر (*rāʾ*) — the little down-curve. Remember Lesson 8: *rā* is a **non-joiner**, so it simply ends the word — but *yāʾ* **does** join into it from the right.

Read back, right to left: خ · ي · ر = *kh · ī · r* = خير, “good.” (The root **kh-y-r** means “good, best, choice” across Semitic — the same three consonants carry the meaning, vowels laid on top, just like Arabic always works.)

Script — Then بخير — “(I’m) well”

Glue ب (*bi-*, “in / with”) onto the front — *bāʾ* from Lesson 3, its one dot below — and it joins straight into the *khāʾ*:

- بخير = *bāʾ · khāʾ · yāʾ · rāʾ* = **bi-khayr**, literally “**in goodness**” — what you say when someone asks *kayfa ḥāluk?* (“how are you?”). “*Al-ḥamdu lillāh, bi-khayr*” — “Praise God, (I’m) well.”

You have now written a **real reply** in a real conversation, in your own hand.

Your turn

- Write it: خير, right to left — “*khāʾ* (dot above), *yāʾ*, *rā* — lift”
- Write it: بخير — add *bi-* on the right: “*bāʾ* joins into *khāʾ*”
- Say it: “the root **kh-y-r** = good; *bi-khayr* = ‘in goodness’ = ‘I’m well’”

Before you move on

Spell خـ letter by letter, right to left. (*khāʾ · yāʾ · rā* — “good.”) Which letter ends it, and does anything join *after* it? (*rā* — **no**, it’s a non-joiner; the pen lifts.) What does بخير literally mean, and when

do you say it? (“**In goodness**” — the answer to “how are you?”, *kayfa ḥāluk?*.) You can now hand-write a greeting *and* its reply — the Arabic script is yours.

3.4 كيف (kayfa) — “how”

Chapter 2 gave you ما (*mā*, “what”). Here is its partner: كيف (*kayfa*, “how”). Two question words, and you can already build with both.

You’ll want to know — The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) ك (*kāf*) and ي (*yāʾ*) you have written — *kāf* in the writing set, *yāʾ* in اسمي. The last letter, ف (*fāʾ*, the *f*), is **new**; the writing track hasn’t reached it yet, so read it for now and draw it later.

Right to left: ك • ي • ف → *kay-fa*.

Note the **ay** in the middle — the *yāʾ* is doing double duty again, this time as part of a diphthong, exactly as it did as a long *ī* in *ismī*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

كيف is a **question word**, so it doesn’t behave like the root-and-pattern nouns you’ve been meeting — it just *is*. But the letters **k–y–f** do form a root elsewhere:

word	meaning
kayfiyya	quality, manner — literally “ how-ness ”
kayyafa	to adapt, adjust (to make a thing fit <i>how</i> it must be)
takyīf	adaptation — and, in modern Arabic, air conditioning

So the abstract noun for “quality” is built straight from the word “how.” Arabic does this constantly: take a word, run it through a pattern, get a concept.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*kayfa*” — “how”
- the pair — “مَا *mā* (what) · كيف *kayfa* (how)”
- “*kayfiyya*” — and hear “how-ness”

Before you move on

What does كيف mean? (“**How**.”) Which Chapter 2 word is its partner? (ما, “what”.) Which letter in it is new? (ف, *fāʾ* — the *f*.) What is *kayfiyya*? (“**Quality**” — literally *how-ness*, built from this very word.) Next: the word Arabic asks about when it asks how you are — and it isn’t “you.”

3.5 حال (*ḥāl*) — “state, condition”

English asks “how are **you**?” Arabic asks about something else entirely — your حال, your *state*. Get this word and the whole question falls open.

You’ll want to know — The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) Three letters, **all already yours**: ح (*ḥāʾ*, the deep throat *h*, from the hook-family lesson), ا (*alif*), ل (*lām*).

Right to left: ح · ا · ل → *ḥāl*. And remember from the writing set: *alif* **breaks** the join, so *ḥā-* then *-l*.

Why it’s said this way

Here is the payoff. حال comes from the root **ḥ-w-l**, “**to turn, to change**.” Look what grows from it:

word	meaning	the turning inside
ḥāl	state, condition	how things have turned out
ḥawla	around	turning <i>round</i> something
taḥwīl	transformation, transfer	making something turn into another
ḥawl	a year	one full turn of the seasons
aḥwāl	circumstances (plural of ḥāl)	the way things stand

So a “state” in Arabic is not a fixed thing you *are* — it’s the position you have **turned to**. The language builds “condition” out of motion. Compare what you already know: Spanish *estar* (“to be, temporarily”) came from Latin *stāre*, “to **stand**.” Two languages, two metaphors for the same idea — one **stands**, one **turns**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ḥāl” — deep ḥ from the throat, not an English *h*
- “ḥāl · ḥawla · taḥwīl” — hear the root turning
- the contrast — “Arabic **turns**, Spanish *estar* **stands**”

Before you move on

What does حال mean? (“**State, condition.**”) What root is it from, and what does that root mean? (ḥ–w–l, “**to turn, change.**”) So what is a “state,” literally? (**How things have turned.**) What is ḥawl? (“**A year**” — one full turn.) Next: bolt a “your” onto it and you have the question.

3.6 كَيْفَ حَالُكَ؟ (kayfa ḥāluka?) — “how are you?”

Everything in this question is already yours. You are not learning a new phrase — you are **bolting three known pieces together**.

You'll want to know — The assembly

piece	where you met it
كيف <i>kayfa</i> — “how”	last-but-one lesson
حال <i>ḥāl</i> — “state”	last lesson
ك <i>-ka / -ki</i> — “your”	new , but see below

→ حالك؟ كيف = “**how** [is] **your state**?”

Grammar Lens — The suffix you already half-know

In Chapter 2 you attached *ي* (-ī, “my”) to a noun: *ism* → **ismī** (“my name”). The suffix for “**your**” works **identically** — it just clips onto the end:

- حالك *ḥāluka* — “your state,” said **to a man**
- حالك *ḥāluki* — “your state,” said **to a woman**

And look at that split: **-ka** to a man, **-ki** to a woman. That is exactly the *أنتَ / أنتِ* (*anta / anti*) division from Chapter 2 — Arabic marking gender, not formality, where Spanish and French mark register. The same *fatha / kasra* mark that flipped *anta* to *anti* flips *ḥāluka* to *ḥāluki*. **One letter, one mark, both meanings.**

Grammar Lens — No verb at all

Notice what is **missing**: there is no “is,” no “are.” Just *how* — *your-state*. This is the **zero copula** you met with *اسمي* (“my name [is] ...”): Arabic simply doesn’t need a verb to join a thing to its description.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- to a man — “*kayfa ḥāluka*?”
- to a woman — “*kayfa ḥāluki*?”
- the parallel — “*ismī* my name · *ḥāluka* your state”
- the missing word — “how · your-state — **no 'is'**”

Before you move on

What does كيف حالك؟ literally say? (“**How [is] your state?**”) Which suffix means “your,” and how does it split? (**-ka** to a man, **-ki** to a woman — the *anta/anti* split again.) Which Chapter 2 suffix does it copy? (**-ī**, “my,” as in *ismī*.) What word is absent from the sentence? (“**Is**” — the zero copula.) Next: how to answer.

3.7 بخير (bi-khayr) — “well”

The answer to *kayfa ḥāluka?* — and you have **already written this word by hand**. Nothing here is new; it is two old pieces stuck together.

You’ll want to know — The letters in this word

(Skim if you read Arabic.) ب (*bāʾ*), خ (*khāʾ*), ي (*yāʾ*), ر (*rāʾ*) — every one of them from the writing set, where you assembled *خير* and then *بخير* letter by letter. Right to left: ر · ي · خ · ب.

You’ll want to know — The two pieces

خير (*khayr*) — “**good, goodness.**” You have met it before without being told: it is sitting inside the Chapter 1 greeting *الخير صباح* (*ṣabāḥ al-khayr*, “morning of **the good**”). The greeting was never a fixed lump — it was always *ṣabāḥ* + *al-* + *khayr*.

ـِ (*bi-*) — “**in, with.**” A **one-letter preposition**, and like *ال* (*al-*) from Chapter 1, it does not stand alone: it **glues** onto the front of the next word.

→ *بخير* = *bi-* + *khayr* = “**in goodness.**”

You’ll want to know — What you actually say

- — كيف حالك؟ *kayfa ḥāluka?* (“How is your state?”)
- — شكراً بخير، *bi-khayr, shukran.* (“Well, thank you.”)

Literally: “*In goodness, thanks.*” Not “I am fine” — Arabic doesn’t need the “I am” any more than the question needed an “is.”

You'll want to know — The bi- you have heard before

That same ب opens the most-spoken phrase in the language: الله بسم (*bismillāh*, “in the name of God”) — *bi-* + *ism* (the very word from Chapter 2!) + *allāh*. One tiny letter, doing the same job.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*bi-khayr*” — “in goodness”
- the callback — “*ṣabāḥ al-khayr ... bi-khayr*”
- the exchange — “*kayfa ḥāluka? — bi-khayr, shukran.*”
- “*bismillāh*” — and find *ism* inside it

Before you move on

What does بخير literally mean? (“**In goodness.**”) Where had you already met *khayr*? (Inside الخير صباح — “morning of the good.”) What kind of word is ب? (A **one-letter preposition** that attaches, like *al-*.) What is missing from the answer, again? (Any word for “**I am.**”) Next: the answer Arabic gives even more often.

3.8 لله الحمد (al-ḥamdu lillāh) — “praise be to God”

Ask an Arabic speaker how they are and this, more often than *bi-khayr*, is what comes back. It also hides the best root story in the chapter.

You'll want to know — The letters

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) ا ل م ح د and ه ل ل — **every letter is one you have written**: *alif*, *lām*, *ḥā*², *mīm*, *dāl*, *hā*². Nothing new to draw.

You'll want to know — The pieces

piece	meaning	where from
ال <i>al-</i>	“the”	Chapter 1
حمد <i>ḥamd</i>	praise	new , root ḥ–m–d
لي <i>li-</i>	“to, for”	a one-letter preposition, like <i>bi-</i>
الله <i>allāh</i>	God	<i>al-</i> + <i>ilāh</i> , “ the god”

→ الله الحمد = “**the** praise [is] **to** **God**.” Zero copula once more.

Note الله itself: it is *al-* (the article you learned in Chapter 1) fused onto *ilāh*, “a god.” The word is literally “**the** **God**.” Its Semitic cousins are Hebrew **El** and **Elohim** — the same family pairing as *salām* / *shalom* from Chapter 1.

Why it's said this way

ḥ–m–d means “**to** **praise**.” Run it through Arabic's patterns:

word	pattern meaning
ḥamd	praise (the plain noun)
maḥmūd	praised
ḥamīd	praiseworthy
aḥmad	“more praiseworthy” — the name Ahmad
muḥammad	“the much-praised one” — the name Muhammad

So the most frequently used phrase in the language and the most common given name on earth are built from **the same three consonants**. This is the root engine doing exactly what Chapter 1 promised: three letters, and a whole family of meanings drops out.

You'll want to know — Using it

- — كيف حالك؟ *kayfa ḥāluka?*
- — الله الحمد. *al-ḥamdu lillāh.*

It works as “fine, thanks” — said whether things are going well or badly, which is part of its point.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*al-ḥamdu lillāh*”
- the root — “*ḥamd · ḥamīd · aḥmad · muḥammad*”
- “*allāh*” — and hear *al-* + *ilāh*, “**the** god”
- the full exchange — “*kayfa ḥāluka? — al-ḥamdu lillāh.*”

Before you move on

What does الحمد لله literally say? (“**The praise [is] to God.**”) What root is *ḥamd* from? (**ḥ–m–d**, “to praise”). Which two names come out of that root? (**Aḥmad** and **Muḥammad** — “the much-praised.”) What is *allāh* made of? (*al-* + *ilāh* = “**the** god”; cousin of Hebrew *El*.) Next: practice the whole exchange.

3.9 Practice — the whole exchange

Chapter 1 let you greet. Chapter 2 let you introduce yourself. This chapter closes the loop: you can now **ask after someone and answer back**.

The exchange

	Arabic	literally
A	عليكم السلام	peace [be] upon you
B	السلام وعليكم	and upon you, peace
A	حالك؟ كيف	how [is] your state?
B	بخير لله، الحمد	the praise [is] to God — in goodness
B	اسمك؟ ما وأنت؟	and you? what [is] your name?

Read down the right-hand column. **Not one line contains a verb “to be.”** Arabic joins things by putting them next to each other.

You'll want to know — the pieces

phrase	built from
<i>kayfa ḥāluka</i>	<i>kayfa</i> + <i>ḥāl</i> + -ka/-ki
<i>bi-khayr</i>	bi- + <i>khayr</i> (already inside <i>ṣabāḥ al-khayr</i>)
<i>al-ḥamdu lillāh</i>	<i>al-</i> + <i>ḥamd</i> + li- + <i>allāh</i>
<i>ismuka</i>	<i>ism</i> + -ka/-ki — the same suffix as <i>ḥāluka</i>

Three tiny attaching pieces — **al-**, **bi-**, **li-** — and two suffixes, **-ī** and **-ka/-ki**. That is most of the chapter.

Grammar Lens — gender

Every “you” in this chapter splits. Say the pair aloud:

to a man

to a woman

kayfa ḥāluka?

kayfa ḥāluki?

mā ismuka?

mā ismuki?

anta

anti

One vowel mark decides — the *fatha* / *kasra* pair from the writing set.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the full exchange, both parts, to a man
- *Say it*: it again, to a woman — every *-ka* becomes *-ki*
- *Write it*: بخير — you have every letter
- *Say it*: the roots met so far — “**s-l-m** peace · **ḥ-w-l** turn · **kh-y-r** good · **ḥ-m-d** praise”

Before you move on

Ask “how are you?” to a woman. (*Kayfa ḥāluki?*) Give both answers. (*Bi-khayr* / *al-ḥamdu lillāh*.) What do *al-*, *bi-* and *li-* have in common? (All **attach** to the next word — they never stand alone.) What single word is absent from every line of the dialogue? (“**Is**” — the zero copula.) Which root gave both a common phrase and a common name? (**ḥ-m-d** — *al-ḥamdu lillāh* and *Muḥammad*.) Next chapter: **farewells** — and the root that started it all comes back.

Chapter 4

Farewells

4.1 ع (‘ayn) — the eye that became an O

This is the letter people think of when they think “Arabic.” ع (‘ayn) writes a sound made **deep in the throat** — one English simply does not have. And its history holds the best surprise in the whole alphabet: this consonant is the ancestor of our vowel **O**.

Script — Draw it

Break it apart — *an open curve, then a bowl*:

1. **the open-mouth curve** on top — like a small **c** opening to the left.
2. **the bowl below**, when ‘ayn stands alone or ends a word — a scoop underneath.

Joined in the middle of a word it flattens into a little wedge; standing alone it shows the full curve-over-bowl. It is a **connector**, so it changes coat by position like *sīn* and *lām*.

Script — A third dots-family

You know the **bowl** family (ب/ن/ت/ث) from Lesson 4 and the **hook-and-tail** family (ح/خ/ج) from Lesson 7. ‘ayn opens a **third**: its skeleton is shared with غ (*ghayn*), which is the **same shape plus one dot above**. Same trick, third time — by now you should expect it.

Script — The surprise: ‘ayn → O

‘ayn comes from Phoenician **‘ayin**, meaning “**eye**” — and the oldest forms were drawn as one. When the **Greeks** borrowed the Phoenician alphabet,

they had **no throat-sound** like ʿ. So they did what borrowers do with a sign they can’t use: they **repurposed** it — and turned the eye-shaped letter into the vowel **omicron**, our **O**.

So the round **O** you write is a Phoenician **eye**, and Arabic’s ʿayn is the same sign that kept its original consonant job. (Compare the thread so far: ʾālep→**A**, bēt→**B**, mem→**M**, kaph→**K**, rēsh→**R** — and now ʿayin→**O**.)

Script — Where you’ve heard it

You have been *saying* this sound since Chapter 1: عليكم السلام (*as-salāmu ʿalaykum*) — the ʿ in ʿalaykum is this letter. And the farewell you’ll write two lessons from now, السلامة مع, opens with it.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ع — the open curve, then the bowl beneath
- *Say it:* the sound, from the throat — as in ʿalaykum
- *Say it:* the family — “ʿayn ع, and ghayn غ = the same shape **plus one dot**”
- *Say it:* “ʿayin = **eye** → the Greeks made it **O**”

Before you move on

Describe ع’s two pieces. (An **open-mouth curve** on top, a **bowl** below when isolated or final.) What did Phoenician ʿayin mean, and what letter did the Greeks turn it into? (“**Eye**”; they had no such sound, so they made it the vowel **O**.) Which letter shares its skeleton? (غ ghayn — one dot above.) Next: ه and the feminine ending ة.

4.2 ه and ة — the loop, and the ending that means “feminine”

Two related shapes. ه (*hāʾ*) is a plain “h” — and the most **shape-shifting** letter you’ve met, wearing four genuinely different coats. Then ة, a letter built *out of* it, whose whole job is to say one grammatical thing: **this word is feminine**.

Script — $\aleph$ ($h\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$) — the loop that never looks the same

Break it apart — there is really just *one piece*:

1. **the loop** — a closed round body.

But that loop **changes shape a lot by position** more than any letter so far: standing alone it's a neat circle-ish loop; at the start it opens out; in the middle it becomes a small figure-of-eight pinched in the centre; at the end it trails. Same letter, four faces — the four-coats rule from Lesson 2 taken to its extreme.

From Phoenician **$h\bar{e}$** — the ancestor of Greek *epsilon* and Latin **E**. (Another one for the family tree: $^{\text{ḥ}}\bar{a}lep \rightarrow A$, $b\bar{e}t \rightarrow B$, $h\bar{e} \rightarrow \mathbf{E}$, $mem \rightarrow M$, $^{\text{ḥ}}ayin \rightarrow O$.)

Script — ḥ ($t\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}} \text{ marbūṭa}$) — the “tied $t\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$ ”

Now look carefully at this:

- $\aleph = h\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$'s loop, **no dots**.
- $\text{ḥ} = \text{the same loop} + t\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$'s **two dots above**.

Its name says exactly what it is: **$t\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}} \text{ marbūṭa}$** , “the **tied-up $t\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$** ” — a ḥ ($t\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$, Lesson 4) whose ends have been **tied into a loop**. It appears **only at the end of a word**, and it is the standard mark of a **feminine** noun or adjective.

You already know its partner: back in Lesson 4 you learned ḥ with **two dots above**. Put those same two dots on a $h\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$ loop and you get the feminine ending. Nothing new to memorise — just two known pieces combined.

Where you've seen it: the farewell **مع السلامة** ($ma^{\text{ḥ}}a s\text{-}sal\bar{a}ma$) ends in ḥ — *salāma* is feminine. That's the next lesson.

Your turn

- *Write it:* $\aleph$ — the loop; then try it isolated and final, feel it change
- *Write it:* ḥ — the same loop, **plus $t\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$'s two dots above**
- *Say it:* the name — “ $t\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}} \text{ marbūṭa}$, the **tied $t\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$** — it marks the feminine”
- *Say it:* “ $h\bar{e} \rightarrow$ Greek epsilon $\rightarrow$ Latin **E**”

Before you move on

What makes ه unusual among the letters you've learned? (Its **loop changes shape** dramatically by position — four very different coats.) What is ة made of, and what does its name mean? (*hā'*'s loop + *tā'*'s **two dots**; “**tied tā'**”). What does ة tell you about a word, and where can it appear? (That it is **feminine**; only at the **end**.) Next: assembling the farewell مع السلامة.

4.3 مع السلامة — the goodbye, and a word you already know

The closing move. مع السلامة (*ma^ʿa s-salāma*) is how Arabic says goodbye — literally “**with safety**,” *go in peace*. And the heart of it is a word you wrote **all the way back in Lesson 3**: سلام. Everything since has been leading here.

Script — Part 1 — مع (*ma^ʿa*, “with”)

Two letters, both known:

1. م (*mīm*, Lesson 3) — round head, joining left into...
 2. ع (*ʿayn*, Lesson 10) — the open curve over its bowl, closing the word.
- مع = *ma^ʿa*, “with.”

Script — Part 2 — السلامة (*as-salāma*, “the safety”)

Look at what this is made of:

- ال — the **al-** (“the”), *alif* + *lām*, both from Lessons 1–2. You’ve read it since Chapter 1 in خيرال and عليكم سلامال.
- سلام — the **exact word you assembled in Lesson 3**: *sīn* · *lām* · *alif* · *mīm*.
- ة — the *tāʾ marbūʿa* from Lesson 11, marking *salāma* as **feminine**.

So السلامة = *al-* + *salām* + *-a*. You are not learning a new word; you are **adding two edges** to one you already own.

Script — The root s-l-m, one more time

salām, salāma, islām, muslim — all from the Semitic root **s-l-m**, “peace, safety, wholeness.” The greeting you learned first (عليكم السلام, “peace be upon you”) and the farewell you learn last (مع السلامة, “with safety”) come from the **same three consonants**. Arabic opens and closes a conversation with one idea.

Script — Assemble it — right to left

1. م then ع → مع 2. lift; ل + ل (the *al-*), the *lām* joining into... 3. ل · س · ل — and remember the لا ligature, and that *alif* **breaks**... 4. م, then ة to close.

→ مع السلامة

Your turn

- *Write it:* مع — mīm into ^cayn
- *Write it:* السلامة — “the *al-*, then your Lesson-3 word, then the feminine ة”
- *Say it:* “ma^ca s-salāma — **with safety**”
- *Say it:* the bookend — “عليكم السلام to greet, مع السلامة to part — same root **s-l-m**”

Before you move on

What does مع السلامة literally mean? (“**With safety**.”) Which earlier word sits inside السلامة, and what was added? (سلام from Lesson 3 — plus ل in front and ة behind.) What does the final ة signal? (*salāma* is **feminine**.) What root ties the first greeting to the last farewell? (**s-l-m** — peace/safety.) You can now hand-write an Arabic conversation from hello to goodbye.

4.4 مع (ma^ca) — “with”

Two letters, both already yours, and a word that will carry the whole chapter.

You'll want to know — The letters

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) م (mīm) from Lesson 3 of the writing set, and ع (ʿayn) from Lesson 10 — the throat sound whose Phoenician ancestor meant “eye,” and which the Greeks recycled into the vowel O.

Right to left: م · ع → maʿa. The ʿayn is not a vowel; it is a constriction deep in the throat. Take your time with it.

You'll want to know — The word

مع (maʿa) = “with, together with.”

It is a **preposition**, and unlike ال (al-) or bi- (bi-) from Chapter 3, it is a **free-standing word** — it does not glue onto the next one. Compare:

	attaches?
ال al- “the”	yes
bi- “in/with”	yes
li- “to”	yes
مع maʿa “with”	no

So Arabic has *two* words touching on “with”: the one-letter bi- (bi-, “in/by means of,” as in *bi-khayr*) and the full word مع (maʿa, “accompanied by”). *Bi-khayr* is “in goodness”; *maʿa* is standing **next to** something.

Why it's said this way

maʿa ← Semitic **cimma*, and its Hebrew cousin is מֵעַ (ʿim), “with.” The same pairing you met with **salām** / **shalom** in Chapter 1 and **ism** / **shem** in Chapter 2. Three chapters, three cousins — the family resemblance is systematic, not a coincidence.

Your turn

- Say it: “maʿa” — the ʿayn from the throat
- Say it: the contrast — “*bi-khayr* **in** goodness · *maʿa* **with**”
- Say it: the cousin — “*maʿa* · Hebrew ʿim”
- Write it: مع — mīm joining into ʿayn

Before you move on

What does مع mean? (“**With.**”) Does it attach to the next word, like *al-* and *bi-*? (**No** — it stands alone.) What is the difference between *bi-* and *ma^ca*? (*Bi-* = “**in/by** means of”; *ma^ca* = “**accompanied by**”). What is its Hebrew cousin? (*^cim.*) Next: the word it goes with — and you already know most of it.

4.5 السلامة (as-salāma) — “the safety”

This looks like a long new word. It isn’t. It is **one word you learned in Chapter 1** with a piece added at each end.

You’ll want to know — Taking it apart

piece	what it is	met in
ال	<i>al-</i> , “the”	Ch. 1
سلام	<i>salām</i> , “peace”	Ch. 1 — the very first word
ة	<i>tā^o marbūṭa</i> , feminine ending	writing Lesson 11

→ السلامة = *al-* + *salām* + *-a* = “**the safety.**”

Every letter is one you have already written by hand.

You’ll want to know — The pattern that changed the meaning

Arabic doesn’t just add endings — it pours a root into a **shape**. Here the root **s-l-m** goes into the pattern *fa^cāla*, which turns a thing into **the state of being that thing**:

word	meaning
salām	peace
salāma	safety, soundness, wellbeing — <i>the state of being at peace</i>

Same three consonants, one new shape, a new but related word. This is the engine Chapter 1 promised, working in front of you.

You'll want to know — Two small rules, both already learned

1. The sun letter. *S* (س) is a **sun letter**, so the *l* of *al-* assimilates to it: written الس, but said **as**-salāma, not *al-salāma*. The same thing happens in عليكم لام الس — the greeting you have said since Chapter 1.

2. The feminine ة. *Tāʾ marbūʿa* marks *salāma* as **feminine**. Arabic abstract nouns very often are.

Your turn

- Say it: “*as-salāma*” — with the doubled *s*, not *al-s*
- Say it: the build — “*salām ... salāma ... as-salāma*”
- Say it: the pattern — “peace → **the state of** peace”
- Write it: السلامة

Before you move on

What three pieces make السلامة? (*al-* + *salām* + ة.) What did the *faʿāla* pattern do to the meaning? (Turned “peace” into “**the state of** being at peace” — safety.) Why is it *as-salāma* and not *al-salāma*? (س is a **sun letter**; the *l* assimilates.) What does the ة tell you? (The word is **feminine**.) Next: put *maʿa* in front of it.

4.6 السلامة مع (*maʿa s-salāma*) — “goodbye”

Put the last two lessons together and the farewell falls out. You have already **hand-written** this phrase; now it means something.

You'll want to know — The assembly

مع (*maʿa*, “with”) + السلامة (*as-salāma*, “the safety”) → السلامة مع
— “**with safety**.”

Said as one run: *maʿa s-salāma* — the *a* of *maʿa* swallows the *al-*’s vowel, and the sun-letter rule doubles the *s*.

It is not “goodbye” in the English sense of a plain sign-off. It is a **wish**: *go in safety*.

You’ll want to know — The circle closes

Look at what Chapter 1 opened with and what Chapter 4 closes with:

	phrase	root
first greeting	عليكم السلام <i>as-salāmu</i> <i>ʿalaykum</i>	s-l-m
last farewell	مع السلامة <i>ma^ʿa</i> <i>s-salāma</i>	s-l-m

The same three consonants. Arabic begins and ends a conversation with one idea — peace, safety, wholeness. The root engine you met in the very first lesson has been running the whole time; here it simply comes back round.

The family, one more time: *salām* (peace), *salāma* (safety), *islām* (submission, i.e. entering peace), *muslim* (one who does so).

You’ll want to know — English does the same trick

Goodbye looks like a single word. It is worn down from *God be with ye*. So the English farewell is also built on “**with**” — you are being commended to something protective as you go.

language	farewell	literally
Arabic	<i>ma^ʿa s-salāma</i>	“ with safety”
English	<i>goodbye</i>	“God be with ye”
Spanish	<i>adiós</i>	“to God”
French	<i>adieu</i>	“to God”

Four languages, one instinct: as someone leaves, hand them over to safekeeping.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ma^ʿa s-salāma*”
- the bookend — “*as-salāmu ʿalaykum ... ma^ʿa s-salāma*”
- the root aloud — “s · l · m”
- “goodbye ← God be **with** ye”

Before you move on

What does مع السلامة literally mean? (“**With safety.**”) What root is it built on, and where have you met that root before? (**s-l-m** — the Chapter 1 greeting *as-salāmu* ‘alaykum, and *salām* itself.) So what does Arabic open and close a conversation with? (**The same idea** — peace/safety.) What is English *goodbye* worn down from? (“**God be with ye.**”) Next: a second farewell, and a word Spanish borrowed.

4.7 اللقاء (ilā l-liqāʾ) — “see you”

The other everyday farewell — and the one with a surprise waiting in the Spanish track.

You’ll want to know — A note on the letters

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) Two pieces here are **beyond what the writing track has covered**, so read them for now and draw them later:

- ق (*qāf*) — a *k* made far back against the soft palate, deeper than ك (*kāf*). It is **not** in the letter set you have been writing from.
- ي in إلى — this is *alif maqṣūra*, “shortened alif”: it wears **yā’s skeleton with no dots** and is pronounced as a long *ā*. You already know from writing Lessons 4–5 that dots are what separate letters sharing a body; this is that same principle, taken one step further.

The rest — ا ل ع — you have written.

You’ll want to know — The two pieces

piece	meaning
إلى <i>ilā</i>	“to, until”
اللقاء <i>al-liqāʾ</i>	“the meeting”

→ اللقاء إلى = “**until the meeting.**”

لقاء (*liqāʾ*) comes from the root **l-q-y**, “**to meet.**” The final ع is the *hamza* from writing Lesson 6 — a glottal stop, a real consonant here, not decoration.

Note ل is a sun letter too, so *al-liqāʾ* doubles the *l*, just as *as-salāma* doubled the *s*.

Why it's said this way

Spanish says goodbye like this:

hasta luego — “**until** later” *hasta mañana* — “**until** tomorrow”

Same shape as *ilā l-liqāʿ*: “**until**” + a **future point**. But it goes further — Spanish *hasta* is itself an **Arabic loanword**, from *ḥattā* (“until”). Of the roughly four thousand Arabic words Spanish took during the eight centuries of al-Andalus, most are nouns; *hasta* is one of the rare borrowed **function words**.

So Spanish did not merely copy the pattern — it borrowed the very word that builds it.

language	farewell	shape
Arabic	<i>ilā l-liqāʿ</i>	until + the meeting
Spanish	<i>hasta luego</i>	until (← <i>ḥattā</i>) + later
French	<i>à bientôt</i>	to + soon
Italian	<i>a presto</i>	to + soon

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ilā l-liqāʿ*” — double the *l*
- the two farewells — “*maʿa s-salāma* · *ilā l-liqāʿ*”
- the loan — “*hasta* ← *ḥattā*”
- the root — “**l · q · y** — to meet”

Before you move on

What does **إلى اللقاء** literally say? (“**Until the meeting.**”) What root is *liqāʿ* from? (**l-q-y**, “to meet.”) Which two letters here has the writing track **not** reached? (**ق** *qāf*, and **ي** *alif maqṣūra*.) What is *alif maqṣūra*? (**Yāʿ’s body with no dots**, pronounced long *ā*.) Which Spanish word for “until” came from Arabic? (***Hasta*** ← *ḥattā*.) Next:

practise the whole conversation, hello to goodbye.

4.8 Practice — the whole conversation

Four chapters. Greet, introduce, ask after someone, part. Here it all is in one piece.

You'll want to know — The full exchange

	Arabic	literally
A	عليكم السلام	peace [be] upon you
B	السلام وعليكم	and upon you, peace
A	اسمك؟ ما	what [is] your name?
B	تشرفنا ... اسمي.	my name [is] ..., we are honoured
A	حالك؟ كيف	how [is] your state?
B	بخير لله، الحمد.	the praise [is] to God — in goodness
A	السلامة مع	with safety
B	اللقاء إلى	until the meeting

Read the right-hand column top to bottom. **Not one line contains a verb “to be.”** The zero copula has held for four chapters.

Why it's said this way

Everything you have learned sits on a handful of three-consonant roots:

root	meaning	words you know
s-l-m	peace, safety	<i>salām, as-salāmu</i> <i>‘alaykum, salāma,</i> <i>ma^{‘a} s-salāma</i>
s-m-w	name	<i>ism, ismī, ismuka</i>
ḥ-w-l	to turn	<i>ḥāl, kayfa ḥāluka</i>
kh-y-r	good	<i>ṣabāḥ al-khayr,</i> <i>bi-khayr</i>
ḥ-m-d	to praise	<i>al-ḥamdu lillāh,</i> <i>Muḥammad</i>
l-q-y	to meet	<i>liqāʾ, ilā l-liqāʾ</i>

Six roots. A whole conversation.

Grammar Lens — The small attaching pieces

piece	job	example
ال <i>al-</i>	the	<i>al-khayr</i>
بـ <i>bi-</i>	in / by	<i>bi-khayr</i>
لـ <i>li-</i>	to	<i>lillāh</i>
ـي <i>-ī</i>	my	<i>ismī</i>
كـ <i>-ka / -ki</i>	your (m./f.)	<i>ismuka, ḥāluki</i>

And مع *ma^ca*, the one that **doesn't** attach.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the full dialogue, both parts, addressing a **man**
- *Say it*: it again to a **woman** — every *-ka* becomes *-ki*
- *Write it*: مع السلامة — every letter is one you have drawn
- *Say it*: the bookend — “السلام to open, السلامة to close”

Before you move on

Give a complete greeting-to-farewell exchange. (The dialogue above.) Which root opens **and** closes it? (**s-l-m**.) Which piece of the chapter doesn't glue onto the next word? (مع *ma^ca*.) What single word is absent from every literal translation? (“**Is**” — the zero copula.) Which Spanish word came from Arabic *ḥattā*? (**Hasta**.) You can now hold — and hand-write — a short Arabic conversation from beginning to end.

Chapter 5

Yes and No

5.1 نعم (na^cam) — yes

A short word to mean yes — with one sound English simply doesn't have.

You'll want to know — The word

نعم = **yes**, said **na^cam**. Arabic reads **right to left**, so its three letters run:

ن (n) · ع (c) · م (m) → **na-^ca-m**

The middle letter ع is the famous **^cayn** — a *pharyngeal* sound made deep in the throat, a tight squeeze with no English equivalent. Don't worry about mastering it today; just know that the little apostrophe-like mark in *na^cam* (the ^c) is standing in for a real, throaty consonant, not a pause.

You'll want to know — Saying yes, and other ways

na^cam is the clear, standard **yes** — polite and safe anywhere. Two neighbours you'll also hear:

- أجل (*ajal*) — a more formal, emphatic “yes, indeed.”
- In everyday speech, many dialects say أيوة (*aywa*) for a casual “yeah.”

And a useful twist: said as a question, **na^cam?** also means “**pardon?** / **you were saying?**” — the same stretch English gives “yes?”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “na^cam” — feel the ع squeeze in the middle of the throat
- right to left — ن · ع · م
- as a question — “na^cam?” = “pardon?”

Before you move on

How do you say yes in Arabic? (**na^cam**, نعم.) Which way does the script run? (**Right to left**.) What is the ع in the middle — a pause or a sound? (A **sound** — the throaty *‘ayn*, with no English match.) What does *na^cam?* mean when you say it as a question? (“**Pardon?**”)

5.2 لا (lā) — no

Two letters, one long vowel — and one of the most recognisable words in the language.

You’ll want to know — The word

لا = **no**, said *lā* (a long *aah*). It’s just two letters — ل (l) + ا (the long *ā*, *alif*) — but they’re written joined into one sweeping shape, لا, a *lam-alif* that Arabic always writes as a single unit. It’s one of the first letter-joins learners recognise on sight.

You’ll want to know — More than an answer

lā isn’t only the reply “no.” It is Arabic’s great word of **negation**, and it opens the most-spoken sentence in the language — the first half of the *shahada*:

لا إله إلا الله — *lā ilāha illā llāh* — “**There is no** god but God.”

That opening *lā* is your word. The same *lā* also negates present-tense verbs — لا أعرف *lā a^crif*, “I do **not** know” — so, like Spanish *no*, one little word is both the answer “no” and the sentence’s “not.”

Grammar Lens — Yes and no, together

You now have the pair:

	Arabic	said
yes	نعم	<i>na^cam</i>
no	لا	<i>lā</i>

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lā” — a long, open *aah*
- the join — ج + ل written as one, لا
- the pair — “na^cam / lā”

Before you move on

How do you say no in Arabic? (lā, لا.) What two letters make it, and how are they written? (ج + ل, joined as a single *lam-alif* لا.) Which famous sentence does *lā* open? (The *shahada* — *lā ilāha illā llāh*.) Besides “no,” what job does *lā* do? (It **negates verbs** — *lā a^crif*, “I don’t know.”)

Chapter 6

Please

6.1 فضلك من (min faḍlik) — please

Arabic doesn't say "please" — it asks for something *from your grace*.

You'll want to know — The phrase

فضلك من — read right to left, **min faḍlik** — is two pieces:

من (*min*, "from") + فضلك (*faḍl* + *-ik/-ak*, "your grace/bounty")
→ "from your grace."

faḍl is a warm, weighty word — "grace, favour, bounty, generosity" (you'll meet it as the name *Faḍl*). Saying *min faḍlik* casts the request as drawing on the other person's generosity — not a command, a courtesy.

Grammar Lens — A gender note (Arabic marks "you")

The ending changes with **whom you address** — and, unwritten, only the vowel moves:

- to a **woman**: *min faḍlik* (the ٱ said *-ik*)
- to a **man**: *min faḍlak* (the ٱ said *-ak*)

The spelling فضلك is the same for both; the short vowel that distinguishes them isn't normally written. One sound to respect: the ض (*d*) is an **emphatic** *d*, said with a heavier, deeper tongue than a plain *d*.

You'll want to know — Another everyday “please”

Just as common, especially getting someone's attention:

سمحت لو — *law samaḥt* — literally “**if you permit**” (*law* “if” + *samaḥt* “you permitted”). Same politeness, a different image — permission rather than grace.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “min faḍlik” — feel the heavy ض
- taken apart — “from your grace”
- the alternative — “law samaḥt” = “if you permit”

Before you move on

How do you say please in Arabic? (**min faḍlik**, من فضلك.) What does it literally mean? (“**From your grace**” — *faḍl* = grace/bounty.) What changes between saying it to a man vs a woman? (The ل ending — *-ak* to a man, *-ik* to a woman; spelling unchanged.) What's the other common “please,” and what does it mean? (**law samaḥt** — “if you permit.”)

Chapter 7

Sorry

7.1 آسف / آسفة (āsif / āsifa) — sorry

You already know من فضلك, “please.” Arabic’s word for “sorry” teaches a new lesson entirely: it isn’t a fixed word at all — **it changes with the speaker.**

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

آسف (*āsif*, said by a man) and آسفة (*āsifa*, said by a woman) both mean “**sorry**.” They come from the verb أَسَفَ (*asifa*), “to grieve, to be filled with regret” — so saying *āsif* is describing yourself as *grieved* / *regretful*, the way you’d say “I am tired” or “I am happy.”

That’s the key: **آسف is an adjective**, and Arabic adjectives **agree with the gender of the person they describe**. A man says آسف; a woman says آسفة — the extra ة (*tāʾ marbūʿa*) is the everyday feminine ending you’ll meet across Arabic adjectives. English “sorry” never changes no matter who says it; Arabic “sorry” always tells you the speaker’s gender in the same breath.

Why it’s said this way

For a quick, **ungendered** “excuse me / pardon” — squeezing past someone, interrupting, a light apology — Arabic reaches for معذرة (*maʿdhira*), from the root ع-ذ-ر (“to excuse”), the same root as عذر (*ʿudhr*, “an excuse”) and the verb يعتذر (*yaʿtadhiru*, “to apologize”). Unlike *āsif/āsifa*, معذرة **doesn’t change with gender** — it’s a noun, not an adjective, so anyone says the same word.

Use آسف/آسفة when you mean a real, felt “I’m sorry” (and remember to

match your own gender); reach for **معذرة** for the light, everyday “pardon me.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a man says — “*āsif*”
- a woman says — “*āsifa*”
- the ungendered one — “*ma^cdhira*” = excuse me / pardon

Before you move on

What’s unusual about **آسف** / **آسفة** compared to English “sorry”? (**It’s a gendered adjective** — *āsif* for a man, *āsifa* for a woman — where English never changes.) What root gives *āsif*, and what does it mean? (**أسف** **asafa**, “to grieve, regret.”) What’s the ungendered word for a quick “excuse me,” and what root is it from? (**معذرة** **ma^cdhira**, from **ر-ذ-ع** “to excuse.”)

Chapter 8

Days of the Week

8.1 الأحد to الخميس (al-aḥad to al-khamīs) — Sunday to Thursday, by the numbers

Every language so far in this course names its weekdays for planet-gods. Arabic does something completely different: it just **counts** them.

Grammar Lens — The pattern: definite article + ordinal number

Five of Arabic’s seven days are simply “**the [number]th**” — the definite article ال (*al-*) plus an ordinal built on the number word:

Arabic	literally	from the number	day
الأحد (<i>al-aḥad</i>)	“the first ”	<i>wāḥid</i> , “one”	Sunday
الاثنين (<i>al-ithnayn</i>)	“the second ” (lit. “the two”)	<i>ithnān</i> , “two”	Monday
الثلاثاء (<i>ath-thulāthāʾ</i>)	“the third ”	<i>thalātha</i> , “three”	Tuesday
الأربعاء (<i>al-arbiʿāʾ</i>)	“the fourth ”	<i>arbaʿa</i> , “four”	Wednesday
الخميس (<i>al-khamīs</i>)	“the fifth ”	<i>khamṣa</i> , “five”	Thursday

No moon, no war-god, no planets at all — just **day one, day two, day three...** This also tells you something about the week itself: counting starts from **Sunday**, so Sunday is “day one” — the Arabic week, like the Jewish and much of the Christian calendar tradition, begins where

the European Monday-first convention doesn't.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “al-aḥad” — the first, Sunday
- count up — “al-ithnayn, ath-thulāthā, al-arbiʿā, al-khamīs” — second through fifth
- contrast — no planet-gods here, just numbers

Before you move on

How does Arabic name Sunday through Thursday? (**As ordinal numbers** — “the first” through “the fifth,” not planet-gods.) Which number is Sunday, and what does that tell you about the week? (“**The first**” — the Arabic week counts starting from **Sunday**.) What Arabic prefix turns a number into “the [x]th day”? (ال *al-*, the definite article.)

8.2 الجمعة and السبت (al-jumʿa, as-sabt) — Friday and Saturday

Five days counted off — and then two days important enough to get **real names** instead of numbers.

You’ll want to know — The two named days

- الجمعة (*al-jumʿa*) = “**the gathering**,” from جمع (*jamaʿa*), “to gather, collect.” This is the day of the congregational Friday prayer (*ṣalāt al-jumʿa*) — the most religiously significant day of the Islamic week, and important enough to earn its own name rather than a number.
- السبت (*as-sabt*) = “**the Sabbath**.”

You'll want to know — Be honest about how السبت differs from Latin's *Sabbatum*

You may remember Latin borrowed the word **Sabbatum** from Hebrew to replace its own pagan *diēs Saturnī* — a loanword crossing from a Semitic language into an Italic one. Arabic's سبت (*sabt*) is a different kind of relationship entirely: Arabic is **itself a Semitic language**, in the same family as Hebrew. So **as-sabt and Hebrew shabbāt aren't borrower-and-lender — they're cousins**, both descending from the same ancient Semitic root س-ب-ت meaning “to rest, to cease.” Where Latin **borrowed** a foreign word, Arabic simply **inherited** a family word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “al-jum^a” — the gathering, Friday
- “as-sabt” — the Sabbath, Saturday
- the contrast — Latin borrowed “Sabbatum”; Arabic’s “sabt” is a blood relative of Hebrew “shabbāt”

Before you move on

Why does الجمعة break the counting pattern? (**It's named for the congregational Friday prayer** — “the gathering” — not counted as a number.) How is Arabic's السبت different from Latin's borrowed **Sabbatum**? (**Arabic and Hebrew are both Semitic languages** — *as-sabt* and *shabbāt* are **cousins** from a shared root, not a loanword crossing between unrelated language families.)

Chapter 9

Four Core Colours

9.1 أسود / أبيض (aswad / abyad) — black and white, a whole new gender pattern

You’ve already met a gendered adjective — آسف/أسف (“sorry”), which just added a feminine ending. Color words go further: they reshape the **whole word**, front and back, for gender.

Grammar Lens — The pattern: masculine إ--- / feminine ---اء

- أسود (*aswad*, masculine) / سوداء (*sawdāʿ*, feminine) — “**black**”
- أبيض (*abyad*, masculine) / بيضاء (*bayḍāʿ*, feminine) — “**white**”

Notice the shape: the masculine form **starts** with إ (a hamza-alif), and the feminine form **drops** that opening letter but **adds** -اء (-āʿ) at the end instead. This isn’t the simple “add one letter” pattern *āsif/ āsifa* used — it’s a **dedicated template** Arabic reserves specifically for **colors and physical characteristics** (this same shape appears again for red and blue in the next lesson).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- masculine — “aswad, abyad” — black, white
- feminine — “sawdāʿ, bayḍāʿ” — black, white
- notice the shape — إ--- drops, ---اء appears

Before you move on

What’s the masculine/feminine pair for black? (أسود **aswad** / سوداء **sawdāʾ**.) For white? (أبيض **abyad** / بيضاء **bayḍāʾ**.) How is this gender-shape different from *āsif/āsifa*? (**It reshapes the whole word** — losing the opening أ and gaining a closing -اء — a template reserved for colors and physical traits, not just adding a simple ending.)

9.2 أحمر / أزرق (**ahmar / azraq**) — red and blue, the same template again

Two more colors — and the exact same shape you just learned.

Grammar Lens — The pattern holds

- أحمر (*aḥmar*, masculine) / حمراء (*ḥamrāʾ*, feminine) — “red”
- أزرق (*azraq*, masculine) / زرقاء (*zarqāʾ*, feminine) — “blue”

Same recipe every time: masculine opens with أ, feminine drops that opening and closes with -اء instead. Once you’ve internalized this template from black and white, the whole family of **classic, old** Arabic colors slots into it (yellow صفراء/أصفر, green خضراء/أخضر, too) — one pattern, several colors. (Newer colors like brown, gray, purple, orange, and pink use a **different** pattern entirely, borrowed from nouns — so “every color” would overstate it; this template belongs specifically to Arabic’s oldest, core color set.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- masculine — “aḥmar, azraq” — red, blue
- feminine — “ḥamrāʾ, zarqāʾ” — red, blue
- all four masculine forms in a row — “aswad, abyad, aḥmar, azraq”

Before you move on

What's the masculine/feminine pair for red? (أحمر **aḥmar** / حمراء **ḥamrāʾ**.) For blue? (أزرق **azraq** / زرقاء **zarqāʾ**.) Does every Arabic color use this same template? (**No** — Arabic's classic, oldest colors (black, white, red, blue, yellow, green) share **one** template, masc. أ--- / fem. ---اء; newer colors like brown or purple use a different, noun-based pattern instead.)

Chapter 10

Family

10.1 أُم, أَب (ab, umm) — father and mother

Two short, ancient words — each just two or three letters — sitting at the root of Semitic family vocabulary across several languages, not just Arabic.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

- أَب (*ab*) = “**father**.” A short, ancient Semitic root, cousin of Hebrew אב (*av*) and Aramaic אבא (*abba*) — the very word behind “**Abba, Father**” in the New Testament.
- أُم (*umm*) = “**mother**.” Equally ancient, cousin of Hebrew אִמָּה (*em*).

These aren’t borrowings between Arabic and Hebrew — both descend from the same ancient Semitic family vocabulary, the way *pater* and English *father* are cousins through PIE rather than one copying the other.

Why it’s said this way

أُم stays productive in everyday Arabic naming: أُم + a child’s name forms a **kunya**, an honorific “**mother of** _____” (and أَبُو, *abū*, does the same for fathers — “**father of** _____”). Someone might be known publicly as *Umm Khālīd*, “mother of Khālīd,” rather than by their own given name — a naming custom still very much alive today.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ab” — father — then “umm,” mother
- the Hebrew cousins — “ab/av, umm/em”
- the naming pattern — “Umm + [child’s name]” = mother of ____

Before you move on

What are Arabic’s words for father and mother? (أب **ab**, أم **umm**.) What are their Hebrew cousins? (**av**, **em** — not borrowings, both from the same ancient Semitic root.) What naming pattern does **umm** still form today? (**Umm** + [child’s name], “mother of ____,” a living honorific.)

10.2 أخ, أخت (akh, ukht) — brother and sister

Unlike the color words you just learned (a whole reshaped template for masculine/feminine), siblings here use the **simplest** possible gender marker.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

- أخ (*akh*) = “**brother**” — another short, ancient Semitic root, cousin of Hebrew אַח (*ach*).
- أخت (*ukht*) = “**sister**” — the **same root**, plus a plain feminine -ت (-*t*) ending, cousin of Hebrew אחות (*achot*).

So *ukht* isn’t a separate word — it’s *akh* wearing the ordinary feminine ending, the simple pattern you already know from آسف/أسفة (*āsif/āsifa*, “sorry”), not the elaborate colors template.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “akh” — brother — then “ukht,” sister

- the shared root plus a simple ending — akh + -t
- the Hebrew cousins — “akh/ach, ukht/achot”

Before you move on

What are Arabic’s words for brother and sister? (أخ **akh**, أخت **ukht**.)
How is *ukht* built from *akh*? (**The same root, plus a plain feminine -ت ending** — the simple pattern, not the colors’ elaborate template.) What are their Hebrew cousins? (**ach, achot**.)

Chapter 11

Head and Hand

11.1 رأس (raʿs) — the head

One more ancient Semitic root — and a word still hard at work in modern political vocabulary, the same way Latin’s *caput* is in English.

You’ll want to know — The word

رأس (raʿs) = “head” — an ancient Semitic root, cousin of Hebrew ראש (rosh), the very word inside **Rosh Hashanah**, “head of the year.”

Why it’s said this way

Arabic builds رئيس (raʿīs), “**president, chief, head [of an organization]**,” directly on this same root — literally “the one who is the head.” That’s exactly the move English makes with Latin *caput*: **captain** (“head” of a unit), **capital** (“head” city). Different language families, the same very human idea — the person or place “at the head” is the one in charge.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “raʿs” — head
- “raʿīs” — president, literally “the head [one]”
- the Hebrew cousin — “raʿs / rosh”

Before you move on

What does رأس mean, and what's its Hebrew cousin? (“**Head**” — cousin of **rosh**, as in Rosh Hashanah.) What word is built on it for “president,” and what does it literally mean? (رئيس *raʿīs*, “the head [one]” — the same “head = leader” idea as English *captain/capital* from Latin *caput*.)

11.2 يد (yad) — the hand

Some words wear their age lightly — worn down, reshaped, disguised. This one hasn’t changed much at all.

You’ll want to know — The word

يد (*yad*) = “**hand**” — a short, ancient Semitic root. Its Hebrew cousin is spelled and pronounced almost **identically**: יד (*yad*). Where *raʿs/rosh* show a family resemblance, *yad/yad* is closer to twins — one of the more strikingly unchanged shared words across the whole Semitic family.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “yad” — hand
- the Hebrew twin — “yad” — almost the same word
- contrast — “raʿs/rosh” changed more than “yad/yad” did

Before you move on

What does يد mean? (“**Hand.**”) How does it compare to its Hebrew cousin? (**Nearly identical** — both *yad* — one of the more strikingly unchanged shared words across the Semitic family.)

Chapter 12

Seasons

12.1 ربيع, صيف, خريف, شتاء — the four seasons

Four words for the turning year — and a genuine reminder that the tidy four-season picture is a **temperate-climate** habit of mind, not a universal one.

You'll want to know — The four seasons

Arabic	meaning
ربيع (<i>rabīʿ</i>)	spring
صيف (<i>ṣayf</i>)	summer
خريف (<i>kharīf</i>)	autumn
شتاء (<i>shitāʾ</i>)	winter

Why it's said this way

ربيع (*rabīʿ*) does double duty: it also names **two months** of the Islamic calendar, **Rabīʿ al-Awwal** and **Rabīʿ al-Thānī** (“first/second Rabīʿ”). That’s worth pausing on, because the **Islamic calendar is lunar** — its months drift across all four solar seasons over roughly a 33-year cycle, unmoored from any actual spring. So a month named “Rabīʿ” won’t reliably fall in spring at all; the name is a fossil from an earlier calendar, kept even as the lunar calendar carried the months loose from the seasons they were once named for.

More broadly: the tidy four-season year assumes a temperate climate with four clearly distinct weather patterns. Much of the Arabic-speaking world spans very different climates — desert, Mediterranean, tropical —

where a strict four-way split maps onto lived experience less cleanly than it does further north. The four words above are the standard Modern Standard Arabic vocabulary, useful and real, but not necessarily the only or most natural way every Arabic-speaking region actually experiences the year.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rabī^c, ṣayf, kharīf, shitā³” — spring, summer, autumn, winter
- the calendar twist — “rabī^c” also names two Islamic months
- the honest note — lunar months drift free of the solar seasons

Before you move on

What does ربيع do besides name a season? (**Names two Islamic calendar months**, Rabī^c al-Awwal/al-Thānī.) Why don’t those months reliably fall in spring? (**The Islamic calendar is lunar** — its months drift across all four seasons over a ~33-year cycle.) Is the four-season frame equally natural everywhere Arabic is spoken? (**Not necessarily** — it fits temperate climates better than the desert/tropical/Mediterranean climates found across much of the Arabic-speaking world.)

Chapter 13

Water and Bread

13.1 ماء, خبز ($māʔ$, *khubz*) — water and bread

Two everyday words — and a study in contrasts: one of them is one of Arabic’s genuinely **oddest** common nouns, and the other is about as **regular** as a word gets.

You’ll want to know — ماء — an old, irregular word

ماء ($māʔ$) = “**water**.” This word is short but **irregular**: its plural (مياه, *miyāh*) and the forms it takes when attached to another noun don’t follow Arabic’s ordinary noun patterns the way most words do. Words this basic — for water, fire, blood, mouth — are often among the oldest in any language family, and old words wear their irregularities proudly; they were already worn smooth by daily use long before the grammar of the rest of the language settled into its regular patterns.

You’ll want to know — خبز — clean, regular, and freshly made

خبز (*khubz*) = “**bread**” — built cleanly on the root ز-ب-خ (*kh-b-z*), “**to bake**.” Where $māʔ$ is a fossil, *khubz* is transparent: the noun for the baked thing, straight from the verb for baking it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ $māʔ$ ” — water — then “*miyāh*,” its irregular plural
- “*khubz*” — bread — from *kh-b-z*, “to bake”

- the contrast — one word is a worn-smooth fossil, the other freshly transparent

Before you move on

What's unusual about ماء? (**It's genuinely irregular** — its plural *miyāh* and attached forms don't follow the ordinary pattern, typical of very old, basic words.) What root is خبز built on, and what does that root mean? (ز-ب-خ, “to bake.”)

Chapter 14

Months

14.1 ديسمبر to يناير — Latin names, borrowed whole, running beside a second calendar

Here's a genuinely different kind of honesty this lesson needs: Arabic doesn't have **one** answer to “what are the months called” — it has **two full calendars**, used for different purposes, side by side.

You'll want to know — Gregorian months

For the everyday, civil, solar calendar, Modern Standard Arabic simply **borrow**s the familiar Latin-derived month names you already know from Spanish/French/English:

Arabic	≈
يناير (<i>yanāyir</i>)	January
فبراير (<i>fabrāyir</i>)	February
مارس (<i>māris</i>)	March
أبريل (<i>abrīl</i>)	April
مايو (<i>māyū</i>)	May
يونيو (<i>yūniyū</i>)	June
يوليو (<i>yūliyū</i>)	July
أغسطس (<i>aghustus</i>)	August
سبتمبر (<i>sibtambir</i>)	September
أكتوبر (<i>uktūbar</i>)	October
نوفمبر (<i>nūfambir</i>)	November
ديسمبر (<i>dīsambir</i>)	December

You can hear the Latin (and French) originals right through the Arabic

sounds — this is a straightforward, recent borrowing for civil/business use, not an ancient Arabic-invented system.

One more honest wrinkle: these Latin-derived names are the everyday convention in Egypt, the Gulf, and much pan-Arab media — but the Levant and Iraq (Syria, Lebanon, Jordan, Palestine, Iraq) traditionally use a **third**, completely different set for these same twelve solar months, of **Syriac** origin: الثاني كانون (*Kānūn al-Thānī*, January), شباط (*Shubāt*, February), آذار (*Ādhār*, March), and so on. So depending on the country, an Arabic speaker’s civil-calendar month name might come from Latin *or* from Syriac — a third naming system, not just two.

Why it’s said this way

For **religious life** — Ramadan, Hajj, and the Islamic calendar generally — Arabic uses an entirely **separate** set of month names, from the **lunar Hijri calendar**: محرم (*Muḥarram*), صفر (*Ṣafar*), ربيع الأول/الثاني (*Rabī^c al-Awwal/al-Thānī* — the very “Rabī^c” from the seasons lesson), and eight more, none of which correspond to a fixed solar month. Because the Hijri calendar has **no leap-month correction**, these twelve lunar months drift steadily across all four solar seasons over a roughly 33-year cycle — so Ramadan, for instance, doesn’t fall in the same season every year.

Two calendars, two jobs: the borrowed Latin names for the ordinary business week, the older lunar names for religious observance.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “yanāyir, fabrāyir, mārīs” — January, February, March — hear the Latin
- the second calendar — “Muḥarram, Ṣafar, Rabī^c al-Awwal” — entirely different names
- the honest point — two calendars, two purposes, both in everyday use

67ديسمبر نوفمبر اكتوبر سبتمبر أغسطس يوليو يونيو مايو أبريل مارس فبراير يناير 14.1.

Before you move on

Where do Arabic's civil month names (*yanāyir, mārīs...*) come from? (**Borrowed Latin/European names**, recent civil-calendar loans.) What runs alongside them for religious life? (**The Hijri lunar calendar**, with its own entirely different 12 month names — *Muḥarram, Ṣafar, Rabīʿ al-Awwal...*) Why do Hijri months drift across the seasons? (**No leap-month correction** — the lunar year is shorter than the solar year, so the calendar drifts over a ~33-year cycle.)

Chapter 15

Noon and Midnight

15.1 الظهر, منتصف الليل — noon and midnight

Noon in Arabic isn't just a clock-time word — it's tied directly into the rhythm of daily prayer.

You'll want to know — الظهر — noon, and a prayer

الظهر (*az-ẓuhr* or *adh-dhuhr*) = “**noon**” — from the root ز-ه-ظ (*z-h-r*), “**to appear, become visible**” (the sun standing at its highest, most visible point). Be honest about what makes this word different from Spanish's *mediodía*: الظهر **is also the name of the midday Islamic prayer**, *ṣalāt al-ẓuhr*. For a Muslim, “noon” and “time for the noon prayer” are the same word — this isn't a neutral clock-time term the way “noon” or *mediodía* are in cultures where the day isn't organized around five fixed prayer times.

You'll want to know — الليل منتصف — a transparent “half of the night”

الليل منتصف (*muntaṣaf al-layl*) = “**midnight**,” literally “**the half of the night**.” منتصف (*muntaṣaf*) comes from the root ن-ص-ف (*n-ṣ-f*), “**half**” (the same root as نصف, *niṣf*, “a half”), and الليل (*al-layl*) is simply “**the night**.” This one is fully transparent — no erosion, no double meaning, just “the middle of the night,” structurally exactly like Latin's *media nox*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “az-ẓuhr” — noon, also the midday prayer

- “muntaṣaf al-layl” — literally “the half of the night”
- the honest point — Arabic noon carries a religious meaning that mediodía doesn’t

Before you move on

What does الظهر name besides the time of day? (**The midday Islamic prayer**, *ṣalāt al-ẓuhr*.) What does الليل منتصف literally mean, and what root gives it “half”? (“**The half of the night**” — *muntaṣaf*, from ف-ص-ن *n-ṣ-f*, “half.”) Is Arabic’s word for noon a neutral clock-time word the way Spanish’s *mediodía* is? (**No** — it’s bound up with the daily prayer schedule.)

Chapter 16

Telling Time

16.1 الساعة — one word for “hour,” “clock,” and “a moment”

Arabic’s word for “hour” isn’t native Arabic at all — it’s a very old borrowing, and it still carries three meanings at once.

Why it’s said this way

ساعة (*sāʿa*) = “**hour**” — but also “**clock/watch**” (as an object) and “**a while, a moment**” (as in “wait a *sāʿa*”). According to the historical linguist Theodor Nöldeke, Arabic ساعة was borrowed from **Aramaic** ܫܥܬܐ (*šāʿtā*) — the same Semitic root that gives Hebrew its word for hour, שעה (*šāʿā*). This borrowing happened long before Islam, deep in Arabic’s pre-Islamic contact with Aramaic-speaking communities — so unlike some of the religiously-tied vocabulary you’ve seen (like *aḏ-ḏuhr*), *sāʿa* is simply an old, everyday loanword, carrying no special religious weight.

Grammar Lens: الساعة كم — “how much is the hour?”

Arabic asks the time with الساعة كم (*kam as-sāʿa?*), literally “**how much/ how many is the hour**” — and answers with الساعة + an ordinal number (“the second,” “the third”...):

الثانية الساعة. — “It is two o’clock.” (literally “the hour [is] the second”) الثالثة الساعة. — “It is three o’clock.” (literally “the hour [is] the third”)

Be honest about the one exception: **one o’clock breaks this pattern.**

You'd expect the ordinal *al-ūlā* (“the first”), but Arabic actually says *الواحدة الساعة* (*as-sā^ca al-wāḥida*) — using **al-wāḥida**, the plain **cardinal** “one,” not the ordinal. So the rule is “ordinal numbers from two o’clock onward, except one o’clock, which uses the cardinal instead” — a genuine irregularity, not a typo. This is still a different grammatical shape than Spanish’s *la una/las dos* or French’s *une heure/deux heures*, both of which use plain cardinal numbers throughout, with no ordinal/cardinal split at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sā^ca” — hour, clock, or a while, depending on context
- “kam as-sā^ca?” — what time is it?
- “as-sā^ca al-thāniya” — it is two o’clock, an ordinal number
- “as-sā^ca al-wāḥida” — it is one o’clock, the one exception, using the cardinal “one” instead

Before you move on

What language did Arabic borrow *ساعة* from, and what Hebrew word is its cousin? (**Aramaic** *šā^catā*; cousin of Hebrew *šā^cā*.) What three things can *ساعة* mean? (**Hour, clock/watch, and a while/moment.**) Does Arabic use cardinal or ordinal numbers to tell the time — and is there an exception? (**Ordinal** from two o’clock onward — “the hour is the *second*” — but **one o’clock is the exception**, using the cardinal *al-wāḥida*, “one,” instead of the ordinal.)

Chapter 17

Asking Someone's Age

17.1 عمرک؟ کم — asking age with a noun, not a verb

You've seen Romance languages **have** their years, Germanic languages **be** their years, and Classical Latin itself use a third construction (“born” + accusative of duration). Arabic does something structurally different again: it doesn't use a verb for this at all.

You'll want to know — عمر — life, lifetime, age

عمر (*ʿumr*) = “age, lifetime, life span” — from the root ع-م-ر (*ʿ-m-r*), broadly tied to the idea of **living, dwelling, flourishing** (the same root behind the personal name **ʿUmar**, and words for “building, habitation”). Age in Arabic isn't something you *have* or *are* — it's expressed as a possessed noun: “your *ʿumr*,” “my *ʿumr*.”

Grammar Lens: عمرک؟ کم — no verb needed

عمرک؟ کم — “How old are you?” (to a man) — literally “**how much [is] your *ʿumr***.” (*kam ʿumruka?*) سنة عشرون عمري.
— “I am twenty years old.” — literally “**my *ʿumr* [is] twenty years**.” (*ʿumrī ʿishrūna sana.*)

Notice there's **no verb “to be” at all** in the present tense here — Arabic simply juxtaposes two nouns (“my age” / “twenty years”), exactly the way it forms ordinary present-tense sentences without *is/are*. So this is a genuinely **fourth shape** for the concept: not Romance's “I **have** twenty years,” not Germanic's “I **am** twenty years [old],” not Latin's “**born** twenty years [so far],” but “**my age [is] twenty years**” —

age as a possessed noun-quantity, stated without any verb at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ʿumr*” — age, lifetime, life span
- “*kam ʿumruka?*” — how old are you? (to a man)
- “*ʿumrī ʿishrūna sana*” — my age is twenty years, no verb at all

Before you move on

What does **عمر** literally mean, and what root is it from? (“**Age, lifetime**” — root **ع-م-ر**, tied to living/flourishing.) Does Arabic use a verb to state age, the way Romance (“have”), Germanic (“be”), or Latin (“born” + duration) do? (**No** — it juxtaposes “my age” and the number, with no verb needed at all.) What does **عمرک؟ کم** literally ask? (“**How much [is] your ʿumr?**”)

Chapter 18

Weather

18.1 الطقس — weather and ritual, one root

Here's an unexpected pairing: Arabic's word for “weather” shares its root with the word for religious “rites.”

You'll want to know — طقس — weather, and its plural means “rites”

الطقس (*aṭ-ṭaqs*) = “**the weather**” — from root س-ق-ط (*t-q-s*). Its plural, طقوس (*ṭuqūs*), means “**rites, religious ceremonies, liturgy**” — the same root covering both “atmospheric conditions” and “prescribed ritual observances.” (Casual speech often prefers الجو (*al-jaw*, “the atmosphere”) instead, keeping *aṭ-ṭaqs* for more formal or written use.)

You'll want to know — بارد / حار الجو — hot and cold, still verbless

حار الجو. — “It's hot.” — literally “**the atmosphere [is] hot.**” (*al-jaw ḥārr.*)
بارد الجو. — “It's cold.” — literally “**the atmosphere [is] cold.**” (*al-jaw bārīd.*)

Same pattern as عمرتك؟ كم from the AGE lesson: **no verb “to be”** at all — just two nouns/adjectives sitting side by side.

You'll want to know — تمطر إنها — but rain gets its OWN personal verb

تمطر إنها. — “It's raining.” — literally “**she is raining.**” (*innahā tumṭir* — from مطر, *maṭar*, “rain,” the same root gives مطر,

tumṭir, “is raining.”)

Unlike *hot* and *cold*, rain isn’t a verbless adjective sentence — Arabic uses an actual **personal verb**, *tumṭir* (“is raining”), with a **feminine dummy pronoun**, *إنها* (*innahā*, “she/it”), standing in as the subject. So within Arabic’s own weather vocabulary, hot/cold stay verbless while rain gets a real, conjugated verb — echoing the same “rain behaves differently from other weather” pattern you saw in Latin’s dedicated *pluit*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “aṭ-ṭaqṣ” — weather, same root as “ṭuqūs,” rites
- “al-jaw ḥarr. al-jaw bārid.” — it’s hot/cold, no verb
- “innahā tumṭir” — it’s raining, with an actual verb

Before you move on

What does the plural of طقس mean, and what’s the connection to “weather”? (طقوس, “rites, religious ceremonies” — sharing the same root.) Do حار الجو and بارد الجو use a verb? (**No** — verbless, like *kam ‘umruka?*.) Does تمطر إنها use a verb? (**Yes** — *tumṭir*, “is raining,” with a feminine dummy pronoun.)

Chapter 19

Numbers One to Five

19.1 خمسة أربعة، ثلاثة، اثنان، واحد — one through five

Before the numbers themselves — an honest correction to a very common mix-up: “Arabic numerals” (the digit shapes **0**, **1**, **2**, **3**...) are **not** these words, and don’t come from Arabic at all.

You’ll want to know — خمسة، أربعة، ثلاثة، اثنان، واحد — the words

Arabic	Transliteration	Meaning
واحد	<i>wāḥid</i>	one
اثنان	<i>ithnān</i>	two
ثلاثة	<i>thalātha</i>	three
أربعة	<i>arbaʿa</i>	four
خمسة	<i>khamṣa</i>	five

These are ordinary Semitic-root Arabic words, built the same way Arabic builds any noun — nothing to do with the shapes of the digits you write.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the correction: the **digit shapes 0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9** that English calls “Arabic numerals” didn’t originate in Arabic at all — they were invented in **India**, appearing in Indian mathematical texts and inscriptions centuries before reaching the Arab world. The 9th-century Persian mathematician **al-Khwārizmī** (whose name gives English **algorithm**) wrote an influential treatise on calculating with these **Hindu numerals**, which carried the system into the Islamic world and then, via Latin translations, into Europe. So “Arabic numerals”

is really a transmission credit, not an origin credit — the shapes are Indian; only their route to Europe ran through Arabic mathematics. The **words** you’re learning here (*wāḥid*, *ithnān*, *thalātha*...) are a completely separate thing: genuine, native Arabic vocabulary, unrelated to that digit-shape history.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “wāḥid, ithnān, thalātha, arbaʿa, khamṣa” — one through five
- the honest correction — “Arabic numerals” (the digit SHAPES) are actually Indian in origin, not these Arabic WORDS

Before you move on

What are the Arabic words for one through five? (**wāḥid**, **ithnān**, **thalātha**, **arbaʿa**, **khamṣa**.) Where did the digit shapes 0-9 actually originate, and who’s credited with carrying them to Europe? (**India** — carried into the Islamic world and then Europe largely through **al-Khwārizmī**’s writings.) Are “Arabic numerals” the same thing as these Arabic number words? (**No** — completely separate: one is a set of written digit shapes with Indian origins, the other is native Arabic vocabulary.)

Chapter 20

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

20.1 عشرون, عشر أحد — plain compounds, then a genuinely different twenty

Eleven through fifteen build the same simple way every time. Then twenty breaks the pattern completely — it isn't built the way you'd expect at all.

You'll want to know — عشر خمسة – عشر أحد — “X and ten”

Arabic	literally
عشر أحد	<i>aḥada ʿashar</i> — “one-ten” (11)
عشر اثنا	<i>ithnā ʿashar</i> — “two-ten” (12)
عشر ثلاثة	<i>thalāthata ʿashar</i> — “three-ten” (13)
عشر أربعة	<i>arbaʿata ʿashar</i> — “four-ten” (14)
عشر خمسة	<i>khamsata ʿashar</i> — “five-ten” (15)

Every one of these is the counting-word (from the AGE and NUM-1-5 lessons) plus عشر (*ʿashar*, “ten”) — a straightforward additive compound, the same shape you've now seen in Spanish's *once-quince* and Latin's *ūndecim-quīndecim*.

You'll want to know — عشرون — NOT “two-ten,” a genuinely different word

Here's the honest surprise: **twenty** is **not** built from “two” + “ten” the way 11-15 were built. عشرون (*ʿishrūn*, “twenty”) is its **own**, distinct word

— a special **plural-like form** built directly on the same “ten” root, ش-ع-ر (^c*sh-r*), rather than a compound of *ithnān* (“two”) and ^c*ashar* (“ten”). That root, ^c*ashar*/^c*ishrūn*, is the same Semitic “ten” root behind Hebrew’s עֶשֶׂר (*eser*, “ten”) — and, coincidentally, resembles the Indo-European “ten” root that gives English its own **-teen** suffix, though the two roots are **not** related: Arabic and English inherited “ten” from two entirely separate language families, so this is a parallel, not a shared borrowing or common ancestor.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “aḥada ^cashar, ithnā ^cashar, thalāthata ^cashar” — 11, 12, 13, “X and ten”
- “^cishrūn” — twenty, its OWN word, not “two-ten”

Before you move on

How are 11-15 built in Arabic? (**X** + ^c**ashar** — “one-ten,” “two-ten,” and so on, a plain additive compound.) Is عَشْرُونَ (twenty) built the same way, as “two-ten”? (**No** — it’s a distinct, standalone plural-like form built on the same “ten” root, not a compound of “two” and “ten.”) What root does ^c**ashar**/^c**ishrūn** share with Hebrew? (ע-ש-ר/ע-ש-ר, the Semitic root for “ten,” giving Hebrew’s *eser*.)

Chapter 21

Dog and Cat

21.1 كلب, قط — a solid root, and the word that closes the loop

You’ve met a genuine dog-word mystery in Spanish, and another one in German by way of English. Arabic’s dog-word has no such mystery — and its cat-word turns out to be a long-lost cousin of nearly every European cat-word you’ve already learned.

Why it’s said this way

كلب (*kalb*, “dog”) traces to **Proto-Semitic** **kalb-* — the exact same root behind **Hebrew**’s own word for dog, כֶּלֶב (*kelev*) (the name **Caleb** is traditionally connected to this same root, though some scholars instead derive it from *kol-lev*, “whole-hearted”). Unlike Spanish’s *perro* or the English word that replaced “hound,” *kalb* is a solid, well-attested, unmysterious Semitic root, shared across the whole Semitic family (Aramaic, Akkadian, and more).

Why it’s said this way

Here’s how this whole arc most likely ties together: قط (*qitt*, “cat, tom-cat”) is not just a coincidence-sounding lookalike — it’s widely **compared** to the exact same ancient **Afro-Asiatic** root behind Latin’s **cat-tus** (alongside Nubian *kadis*, mentioned back in the Spanish and Latin lessons). Be honest about the uncertainty here, though: linguists don’t fully agree on the relationship. Some argue *qitt* and *cattus* both descend from a **shared** ancestor; others have proposed that *kadis* (and even *qitt* itself) could be a **later** borrowing **from** Arabic rather than an inde-

pendent cousin, reversing the direction. What's not in serious dispute is that Arabic's word for "cat" sits in the same tangled word-family as Spanish's *gato*, French's *chat*, Italian's *gatto*, and German's *Katze* — one root (or a tight cluster of related roots), spreading out in every direction from wherever cats were first domesticated, even if the exact family tree is still being worked out.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kalb” — dog, a solid Semitic root, cousin of Hebrew's *kelev*
- “qitt” — cat, most likely a distant cousin of Latin's *cattus* and every European cat-word you've learned

Before you move on

What root does كلب trace to, and what's its Hebrew cousin? (**Proto-Semitic *kalb-**; cousin of Hebrew כֶּלֶב, *kelev*.) Is قطة's relationship to Latin's *cattus* fully settled? (**No** — widely compared, most likely from a shared Afro-Asiatic root, but linguists still debate the exact relationship and direction.) What does this most likely mean for Arabic's word for “cat” compared to Spanish's *gato*, French's *chat*, and German's *Katze*? (**They most likely belong to the same tangled ancient word family** — spreading in every direction from the region where cats were first domesticated.)

Chapter 22

Green and Yellow

22.1 أخضر, أصفر — “greens” you’d recognize, and a hidden zero

Arabic’s green word hides an English-style pun. Its yellow word hides something even better — the exact root behind the word “zero” itself.

Why it’s said this way

أخضر (*akhḍar*, “**green**”) comes from the root ر-ض-خ (*kh-ḍ-r*, “**to be green**”). That same root gives خضار (*khudār*, “**vegetables**”) — echoing the exact same move English makes when it calls vegetables “**greens**.” The same root also names the mysterious Quranic figure الخضر (*al-Khiḍr*), “**the Green One**” — traditionally said to be called this because the ground turned green wherever he sat or prayed.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the real surprise: أصفر (*aṣfar*, “**yellow**”) shares its root, ر-ف-ص (*ṣ-f-r*), with صفر (*ṣifr*, “**zero, empty, void**”) — the **exact** Arabic word that gave English both **zero** (via Italian *zefiro/zero*) and **cipher** (via Medieval Latin *cifra*). So the same three-letter Arabic root sits behind “yellow” and behind the number **zero** itself. The sources don’t fully explain *why* “emptiness” and “yellow” share a root — but the shared root itself, connecting Arabic’s yellow-word straight back to the origin of “zero,” is genuine and well documented.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “akhḍar” — green, same root as “khudār,” vegetables
- “aṣfar” — yellow, same root as “ṣifr,” zero
- the connection — “aṣfar, ṣifr, zero, cipher” — one Arabic root, reaching all the way into English math vocabulary

Before you move on

What root does أخضر share with “vegetables,” and what English phrase does this echo? (ر-ض-خ, *kh-ḍ-r* — echoes English calling vegetables “**greens**.”) What Quranic figure shares this root, and what does his name mean? (الخضر, *al-Khiḍr* — “**the Green One**.”) What word does أصفر share its root with, and what two English words trace back to it? (صفر, *ṣifr*, “zero, empty” — the source of English **zero** and **cipher**.)

Chapter 23

You're Welcome

23.1 عفو (ʿafwan) — “you’re welcome,” from a root meaning “to erase”

Your very first Arabic lesson already used this word once, in passing, as the reply to *shukran*. Here it gets its own full treatment — starting with a root that literally means “to erase.”

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

عفو (ʿafwan), root ع-ف-و (ع-ف-و): the root’s core sense is “**to erase, obliterate, remove**” — and “to pardon, forgive” grows directly out of that, since forgiving something is, metaphorically, **erasing** it. The same root gives العفو (al-ʿafwuww, “**the Supreme Pardoner**”), one of the **99 names of Allah** in Islamic tradition.

You’ll want to know — Be honest: ʿafwan does more than one job

ʿAfwan answers *shukran* as “**you’re welcome**” — but depending on tone and context, the exact same word also does duty as “**excuse me,**” “**pardon,**” or “**sorry.**” One root, one word, several closely related jobs — all growing from that same “erase/pardon” sense.

Grammar Lens: the same ending as shukran itself

Look closely at the spelling: عفو ends in the same **tanwīn fatḥh** (“-an”) you already met in شكرًا (*shukran*) — the indefinite accusative ending. Neither word is a full sentence with its own verb; both are fixed, idiomatic accusative forms functioning as a complete conversational turn

on their own. The grammar you learned once, for *shukran*, already explains *ʿafwan* too.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “عفوًا” — *ʿafwan*, “you’re welcome”
- the root ʿ-f-w — “to erase” → “to pardon”
- the shared ending — *shukran* and *ʿafwan* both end in the same *tanwīn fatḥ*, “-an”

Before you move on

What does the root ʿ-f-w literally mean, before it comes to mean “pardon”? (“**To erase, obliterate.**”) Besides “you’re welcome,” what other jobs can *ʿafwan* do? (“**Excuse me,**” “**pardon,**” “**sorry**” — context-dependent.) What grammatical ending does *ʿafwan* share with *shukran*? (The **tanwīn fatḥ**, “-an” — both are fixed indefinite- accusative forms, not full sentences.)

Chapter 24

See You Tomorrow

24.1 الغد إلى (ilā l-ghad) — “see you tomorrow,” the same ilā again

You already have the pattern: **ilā** + a future point = “see you [then].” Here it is again, with “tomorrow” filling the slot.

You’ll want to know — The two pieces, one already familiar

الغد إلى (ilā l-ghad) = “**until tomorrow**”:

- إلى (ilā) — “**until**,” the exact same word from *ilā l-liqāʿ* (“see you [later]”).
- الغد (al-ghad) — “**tomorrow**,” root **gh-d-w** (غ-د-و).
- Note ج is a sun letter, so *al-ghad* would assimilate — but غ (*ghayn*) is a **moon letter**, so here the *l* stays put: *al-ghad*, not doubled the way *al-liqāʿ* and *as-salāma* were.

Why it’s said this way

Gh-d-w’s core sense is “**to go out at dawn, early morning**” — and “**tomorrow**” grows directly out of that “early morning” sense. This is **not** a one-off coincidence: you’ve already seen this **exact** shift happen in Latin, where *māne* (“morning”) became French’s *demain* and Spanish’s *mañana* (“tomorrow”). Two completely unrelated language families — Semitic and Indo-European — independently building “tomorrow” out of “morning.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ilā l-ghad” — “until tomorrow”
- the reused piece — ilā, already known from ilā l-liqāʾ
- the root echo — gh-d-w, “dawn/morning” → “tomorrow,” the same shift as Latin māne → mañana/demain

Before you move on

What word does **ilā l-ghad** share with **ilā l-liqāʾ**? (**Ilā**, “until.”) What does the root **gh-d-w** literally mean, before it comes to mean “tomorrow”? (**“To go out at dawn, early morning.”**) Is this morning-to-tomorrow shift unique to Arabic? (**No** — Latin’s *māne* (“morning”) independently became French’s *demain* and Spanish’s *mañana*, “tomorrow,” the same way.)

Chapter 25

Day

25.1 يوم (yawm) — “day,” a word shared across the whole Semitic family

This word is bigger than Arabic — it’s one of the oldest, most widely shared words across the entire Semitic language family.

You’ll want to know — يوم — “day”

يوم (yawm) — “day” — root **y-w-m**. Arabic’s day-names can compound with *yawm* — الجمعة يوم (yawm al-jum^a, “day of the gathering”) is the full, formal way to say “Friday,” the exact same “day-of-X” construct-state pattern as Latin’s *diēs Lūnae* — but colloquially, the bare day-name alone (*al-jum^a*, *as-sabt*, already taught earlier) is just as common. *Yawm* itself is also the ordinary, standalone word for “a day.”

Why it’s said this way

Yawm traces to **Proto-Semitic** **yawm-* — and this isn’t just an Arabic word with foreign relatives, it’s a genuinely **Common Semitic** word, found with the same shape and meaning across the whole family: Hebrew יוֹם (*yōm* — yes, the *yom* in **Yom Kippur**, “Day of Atonement”), Akkadian **ūmum**, and Aramaic **yawmā**. Four different Semitic languages, one shared ancient word for “day.”

Why it’s said this way

Some scholars push the trail back even further, to a proposed **Proto-Afroasiatic** root, **yam-* (“day”) — and speculatively connect it to

Egyptian **imy**, meaning “**sun**” (literally “the eye”). Be honest: this deeper connection is a genuinely **proposed**, citable scholarly idea within comparative Afroasiatic linguistics — but a minority one, not accepted by most Egyptologists (standard Egyptian dictionaries gloss *imy* as a common grammatical form, “who/which is in,” not “sun,” and ordinary Egyptian for “day” is an unrelated word, *hrw*). Not settled fact the way the Semitic-family cognates are.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “yawm” — “day”
- the Semitic family — yawm, yōm (Yom Kippur), ūmum, yawmā
- the honest deeper speculation — possibly Egyptian “sun,” not settled

Before you move on

What Hebrew word, familiar from a well-known holiday name, is **yawm**’s direct cognate? (**Yōm**, as in **Yom Kippur**.) Name two other Semitic languages that share this exact word for “day.” (**Akkadian** *ūmum*, **Aramaic** *yawmā*.) Is the proposed Egyptian “sun” connection settled fact? (**No** — a genuinely proposed but speculative deeper link.)

Chapter 26

Night

26.1 ليل (layl) — “night,” yawm’s partner across the whole Semitic family

You’ve already met *layl* once, tucked inside *muntaṣaf al-layl* (“midnight”). Now it gets the same standalone treatment *yawm* just did — and the same pan-Semitic family story.

You’ll want to know — ليل — “night”

ليل (layl) — “night” — is the word already hiding inside **muntaṣaf al-layl** (“midnight,” Chapter 15, literally “the half of the night”). Root l-y-l.

Why it’s said this way

Just like *yawm*, **layl** is a genuine **Common Semitic** word, not an Arabic-only term with distant relatives. It traces to **Proto-Semitic** **layl-*, cognate with Hebrew לַיִל (*layla/laylah* — the same word in the famous Passover question, “*mah nishtana ha-layla ha-zeh*,” “why is **this night** different”), Aramaic/Syriac **lēlyā**, and Akkadian **līliātum**. Day and night, *yawm* and *layl*, are **both** words the whole Semitic family has shared for millennia.

Why it’s said this way

Be honest about one genuine scholarly debate: linguists don’t fully agree on whether Proto-Semitic had this simple **triradical** **layl-* form, or a **reduplicated** **laylay-* form instead (the doubled shape possibly surviving in some daughter languages’ declension patterns). This is a real, open question in comparative Semitics — not settled the way the basic

Hebrew/Aramaic/Akkadian cognate set is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “layl” — “night,” already met inside *muntaṣaf al-layl*
- the Semitic family — *layl*, *layla* (Hebrew), *lēlyā*, *līlātum*
- *yawm* and *layl* — day and night, both pan-Semitic words

Before you move on

Where have you already met **layl** before this lesson? (**Muntaṣaf al-layl**, “midnight.”) What Hebrew word, from a famous Passover question, is *layl*’s direct cognate? (**Layla/laylah.**) Is the exact Proto-Semitic shape of this word — triradical or reduplicated — fully settled? (**No** — a genuine, open scholarly debate.)

Chapter 27

Good Night

27.1 خير على تصبح (tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr) — wishing the morning, not the night

Every “good night” you’ve learned in other languages wishes a peaceful **night**. Arabic’s everyday version does something completely different — it skips the night and wishes the **morning** instead.

You’ll want to know — خير على تصبح — “may you wake into goodness”

خير على تصبح (tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr) is the most common everyday Arabic “good night” — but it literally means “**may you wake up into goodness.**” Break it down:

- تصبح (tuṣbiḥ) — the ordinary imperfect (“you become”) of أصبح (aṣbaḥa, “**to become morning, to wake up**”) — the **exact same root**, ح-ب-ص (ṣ-b-ḥ), as ṣabāḥ in ṣabāḥ al-khayr (“good morning,” Chapter 1). No special subjunctive or jussive form is involved — a plain statement doing the work of a blessing, the same way English “you’ll sleep well” can function as a wish without any special grammar.
- على (ʿalā) — “upon.”
- خير (khayr) — “**goodness**” — the same word already met in masāʾ al-khayr (“good evening”).

Put together: not “sleep well,” but “**may your waking be good.**” (This particular form, *tuṣbiḥ*, addresses one **man**; a woman is *tuṣbiḥā* [تصبحي], a group is *tuṣbiḥū* [تصبحوا].)

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the genuinely different part: **every** other “good night” in this arc — English, French, German, Spanish — wishes something about the **night itself**. Arabic’s everyday version does the opposite: it’s grammatically about the **morning that follows**, built from the same “waking” root already hiding in *ṣabāḥ*. Notice what’s genuinely absent: ليل (*layl*, “night,” last lesson) doesn’t appear anywhere in this phrase at all. It reuses pieces you already have (*ṣ-b-ḥ*, *khayr*) but points them at a **different moment in time** than every other language’s farewell.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr*” — literally “may you wake into goodness”
- the shared root — *tuṣbiḥ* and *ṣabāḥ*, both from *ṣ-b-ḥ*
- the honest twist — this “good night” is really about the morning, not the night

Before you move on

What does *خير على تصبح* literally mean? (“**May you wake up into goodness.**”) What root does *tuṣbiḥ* share with *ṣabāḥ al-khayr*? (*ṣ-b-ḥ*, “morning/to become morning.”) Unlike English, French, and German’s “good night,” what moment in time does Arabic’s everyday version actually point to? (**The morning that follows**, not the night itself.)

Pronunciation & Script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system. Arabic appears both in script (مرحبا) and in transliteration (*marḥaban*), a dot marking the heavy/throaty consonants.

The script, in one breath

- **Right to left**, and letters **connect** — each has up to four shapes (isolated/initial/medial/final). Met inside real words, not drilled.
- Short vowels (*a i u*) are usually left unwritten; long vowels (*ā ī ū*) are letters (ا و ي).

Consonants with no English equivalent

- ح (ḥ): a heavy *h* from deep in the throat (vs. light ه).
- خ (kh): a throat-scrape = Scottish *loch*, **Spanish** *j*.
- ع (ʿ, “*ayn*”): a voiced throat-tightening; no English match.
- ء (ʾ, “hamza”): a glottal stop — the catch in “uh-oh.”
- ق (q): a *k* made far back; غ (gh): a gargled *g*.

Emphatic (“heavy”) consonants

ص ض ط ظ (ṣ, ḍ, ṭ, ṣ): heavier, deeper versions of *s*, *d*, *t*, *dh*. They change the word: ص س $\neq$ س *s*.

The article and sun/moon letters

ال (*al-*, “the”) attaches to its noun. Before a **sun letter** the *l* assimilates and the letter doubles: *al-salām* → *as-salām*. Before a **moon letter** it stays: *al-khayr*. The sun rule is fossilized in Spanish *azúcar* (from *as-sukkar*).

The root system

Most words are built on a **three-consonant root** carrying a core meaning, poured into vowel **patterns**: *k-t-b* (writing) → *kitāb* (book), *kātib* (writer), *maktab* (office). See the first lesson.